

The site is entirely surrounded by a continuous fortification wall, 2.5–3 m thick, with masonry of medium-sized stones. The wall is about 600 m long and passes over the high part of the slope. On the northern slope it stands to a height of 4–5 m, and its inner part has been preserved all round. On the south-west slope, it is preserved now to only 1 m high, but its existence is certain.

The approach to the tell, including the gateway area, is from the south-west. Here the walls branch off. The lowest wall ends in a round tower 20 m in diameter, towering 5 m over the wall. Above, 10 m from it, the upper wall continues with a break for the gateway. In this area the rock was cut in order to widen the approach, 5–6 m wide, with a road leading to the entrance. In the northern part there are four large, man-made steps at the edge of the slope and on its upper part. Apparently these were supporting walls of the original settlement that later became terraces.

At the summit are sparse remains of buildings. According to the rich ceramic find, the entire surface of the tell was built up, and some building stones were later removed. In the centre of the summit is an enclosure, 10×35 m, surrounding an open area on the north, east, and south sides. Of the walls of this enclosure, only piles of small stones remain, following the removal of the large building stones.

There are a considerable number of installations and quarried places at the site. About 30 of these, including winepresses, basins, and oil production installations (from the Iron Age and other periods), were found. There are also many rock-cut cisterns.

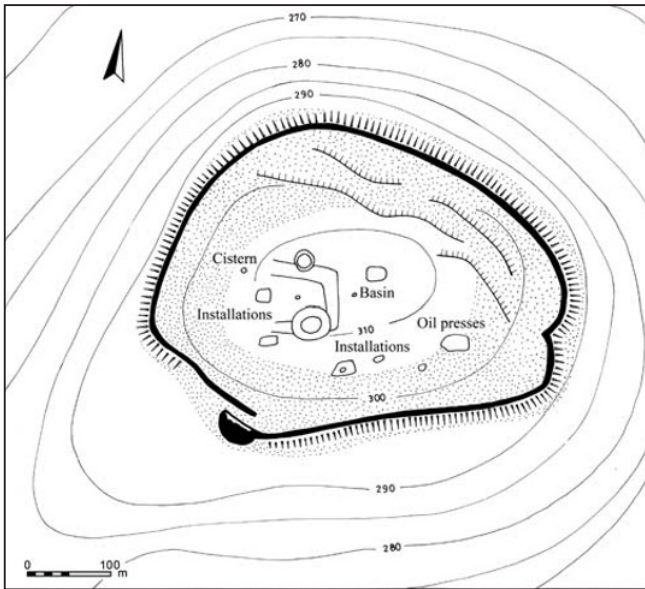
Tell el-'Abeideh is a central and important site in its region, flourishing in the Iron Age and Persian period, and linked with the tells of Sheikh Şabar (Site 99), Muḥaffar (Zertal 2004: no. 23), and Dothan (*ibid.*: no. 44).

Pottery: Iron I – 2%; Iron II – 30%; Iron III – 15%; Persian – 43%; Hellenistic – 5%; Early Roman – 5%.

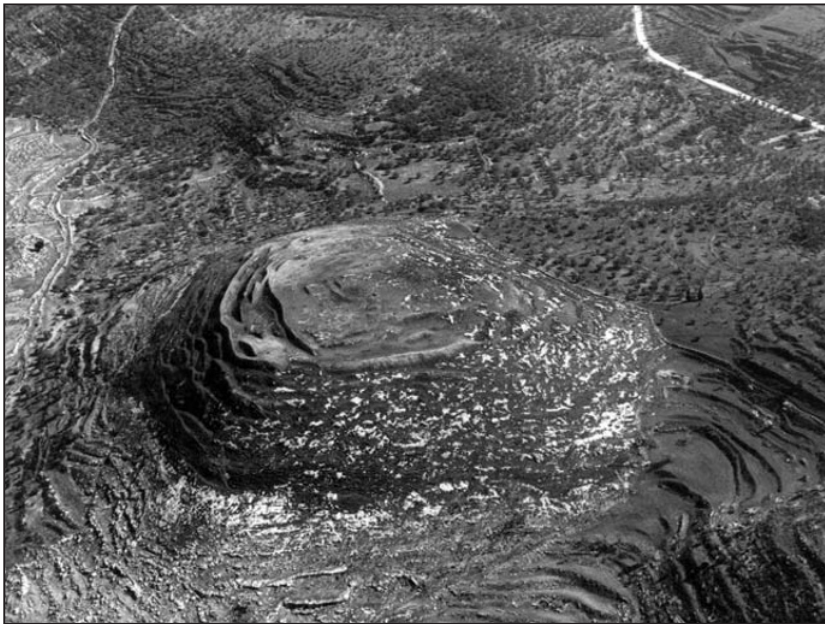
Identification: This was one of the initial candidates to be Arubboth-Narbatah, but the identification was later considered unlikely, given the absence of considerable Roman material. It is most likely to be one of the sites mentioned in the Book of Judith: see discussion in Chapter 2.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 7.

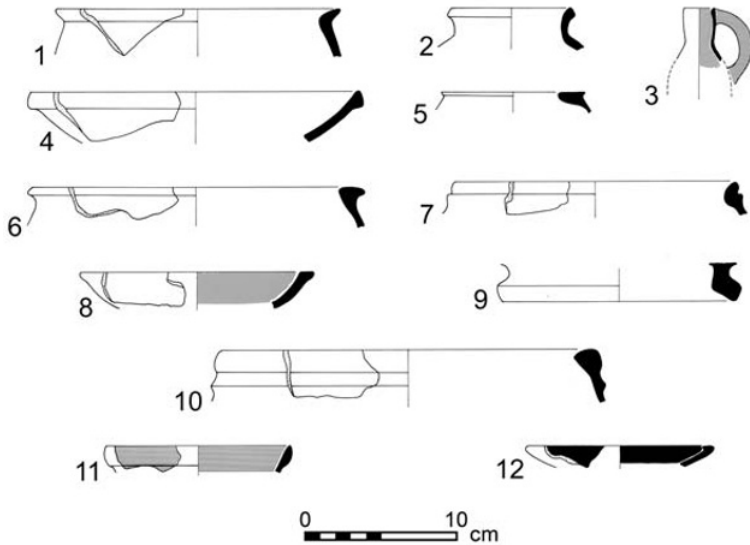
Additional Bibliography: Salem 2006: site 3.



149. Plan of Tell el-'Abeideh, 1997. Note the fortified gateway.



150. Aerial photo of Tell el-'Abeideh, looking south-east. In background, houses of the village of Ya'bad are visible. 1988. Photo: M. Weinberg.



151. Pottery from Tell el-'Abeideh: 1. Krater, brn, IA I; 2. Jar, lt, Pers; 3. Juglet, rd slip, IA II; 4. Bowl, gr, Pers; 5. HM, gr, IA II; 6. Krater, yel, IA I; 7. CP, brn, IA II; 8. Bowl, rd slip, IA II; 9. Mortaria base, yel, Pers; 10. Large krater, brn, IA I-II; 11. Bowl, rd slip inside and out, IA II; 12. Bowl, blk slip, Hel.



Site 114: 15-20/54/1

Khallet el-Gazaz

Israel grid: 1550 2041

UTM grid: 6928 5902

Elevation: 100 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: ravine

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: olives

Cisterns: 1

Water source: 'Ein Beduseh
(no. 152), 500 m distant

Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), 1.5 km
distant

Visibility: 2

Date of visits: 1991; 58 sherds

A small site in a ravine in which olive trees grow, about 1.5 km north of the ancient core of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh.

On the west side of the ravine, adjacent to a cultivated plain, are two structures of large stones about 6×7 m. These were built on the moderate slope of the ravine, and apparently their foundations, of which one layer survived, were levelled prior to construction. A similar building was found on the east side of the ravine, about 50 m from these structures.

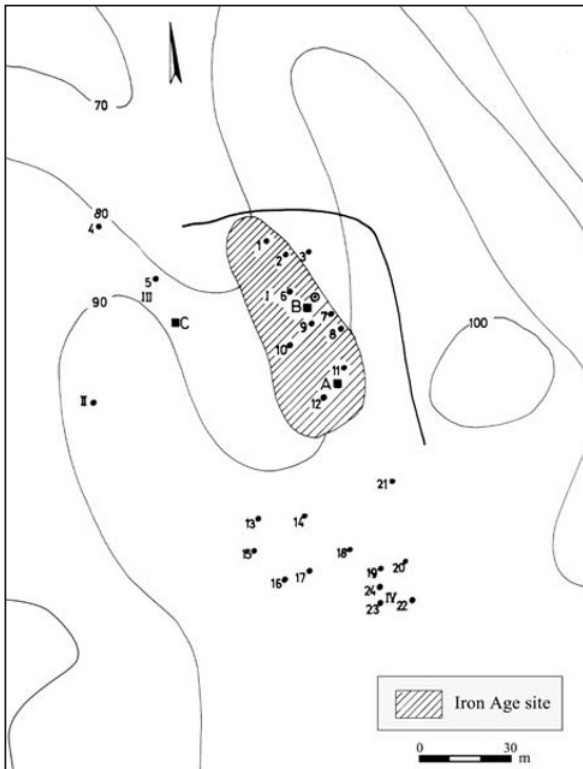
Over an area of 2 dunams (2000 sq. m) around the buildings, scores of rock-cut installations were found. Most of them are rounded, shallow basins of various shapes.

Nearby (Israel grid 1550/2044) Ne'eman (1990: site 47) surveyed two winepresses and remains of quarrying with Roman and Byzantine sherds.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 50%; Iron I – 50%.

Previous surveys: None.

Additional Bibliography: Dauphin 1998, III: site 113; van den Brink 2008: 8; Eitam 2009: 64.



152. Plan of the Khallet el-Gazaz site and its installations.



153. The Iron Age houses of Khallet el-Gazaz, 1990.



Site 115: 15-20/54/2

E.P. 108

Israel grid: 1552 2047

UTM grid: 6930 5908

Elevation: 82 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm (?)

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: slope

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa and rendzina

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Bir Isyar (no. 140),
800 m distant

Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), 2.2 km
distant

Visibility: 3

Date of visit: Nov. 1991; 19 sherds

A small site on the western slope of the range, at the head of E.P. 108 and about 500 m south-east of Kibbutz Metzer. West of the range is a broad, cultivated ravine.

Remains of at least two structures were found here, 5 m apart. They look like piles of cleared stones, 10 m in diameter, with remains of walls

projecting. Their plans are very unclear. About 20 m west of them was a rock-cut winepress, 3×3 m, with a collection vat.

This may have been a farm, founded in Iron Age I. Afterwards it was occupied continuously from Iron Age II to the Herodian period. The residents presumably based their agriculture on the fertile valley to the west.

Pottery: Iron I - 5%; Iron II - 5%; Persian - 30%; Hellenistic - 25%; Early Roman - 35%.

Previous surveys: None.



Site 116: 15-20/64/1

Marj Qaffin

Israel grid: 1566 2048

UTM grid: 6944 5910

Elevation: 115 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: structure

Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: groves

Cisterns: none

Water source: Bir Isyar (no. 140),
1 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 3 km
distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Oct. 1991; 15 sherds

A structure on top of a wide ridge, connected to Khirbet Isyar in the west and to Qaffin in the east.

The dimensions of the structure, which is built of large stones, are 5×12 m. Presumably this was a solitary farmhouse, including a courtyard and a central structure.

Pottery: Byzantine - 100%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 117: 15-20/84/1

Qaffin (on British Survey map: Kuffin)

Israel grid: 1582 2043	forest
UTM grid: 6960 5905	Soil quality: 7
Elevation: 135 m a.s.l., 25 m a.s.a.	Cultivation: none
Name type: appears as Arab village	Cisterns: 48 (in ancient core)
Site type: village on medium-sized ruin	Water source: Bir Isyar (no. 140), 2 km distant
Area: 9 dunams (9000 sq. m) (ancient core)	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 2 km distant
Topography: edge of ridge	Visibility: 3
Rock type: Judah group	Date of visit: Dec. 1982; 38 sherds
Soil type: terra rossa and brown	

A medium-sized village in the area of low hills between the Dothan Valley and the Sharon Plain. It is situated on a broad ridge within Wadi 'Asl, about 4 km east-north-east of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh.

The ancient core is in the eastern part of the village, east of the mosque, next to which are many ancient walls *in situ*, whose masonry is of large stones, including carved stones (lintels, cornices, etc.). In and around the village are burial caves and agricultural installations.

The village was one of the estates given by Sultan Baibars following the victory over the Crusaders in 1265 (Abel 1939: 42). According to the document: "the Emir Rukun ed-Din Baibars el-Mu'izi [received] half of the village of Qaffin" (Lyons 1971: 80). In the Ottoman census of 1596 it appears in the Jenin province, although in the opinion of Hütteroth it does not belong to this province. In the village were 27 Moslem taxpayers, and the village paid 9000 *aqia* in tax. Of this it paid 5040 *aqia* for wheat, 1200 for barley, 550 for summer crops and 1200 for olives (Hütteroth and 'Abdulfattah 1977: 161).

The British Survey describes it as a "good-sized village on the low hills east of the Plain of Sharon, with a well on the south side. It has rock-cut tombs, and a palm grows near the village" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 47).

A tomb from the 1st–2nd centuries CE was excavated by el-Fanni (1971: *Hadashot Arkheologiyot* 40) on the northern slope of the hill of the village. In front of the tomb was a square rock-cut courtyard with carved benches that was apparently roofed by a barrel-shaped vault. *Loculi* were cut into the walls of the burial chamber. Several broken sarcophagi were discovered, among them one with rosette decoration.

In 1978, a Roman bathhouse was discovered at this site by chance (unpublished).

Pottery: Persian – 10%; Hellenistic – 15%; Early Roman – 10%; Late Roman – 25%; Byzantine – 25%; Early Moslem – 5%; Middle Ages – 5%; Ottoman – 5%.

Previous surveys: Ne'eman 1990: site 50.

Additional Bibliography: *Hadashot Arkheologiyot* 33 (1970); Dauphin 1998, III: site 132.



154. Bird's-eye view of the village of Qaffin, facing south-east. Photo: M. Einav, 1997.

Site 118: 16-20/05/1

Wadi Zeidi

Israel grid: 1609 2050

UTM grid: 6986 5912

Elevation: 265 m a.s.l., 37 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 1

Water source: 'Ein Barṭa'ah (no. 20),
4.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1.8 km
distant

Visibility: 3

Date of visit: Nov. 1978; 31 sherds

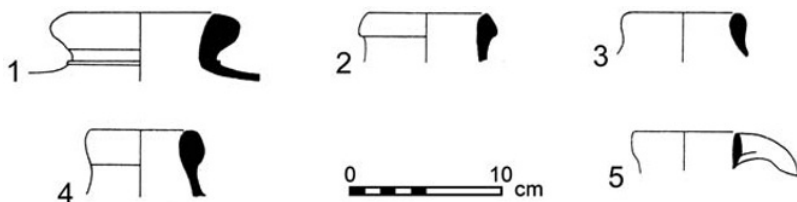
A farmstead on an elongated ridge in the hilly area north-west of the Dothan Valley, between Wadi Lihfeh (erroneously labelled on the 1:50000 map as Wadi Ghamiq) and Wadi Zeidi.

On the ridge, from which there is a good view of the hilly region around Khirbet Mas'ud, is a large structure, 10×13 m, with walls about 1 m thick. It is built of large stones, with a rock-cut cistern about 10 m to the east.

Along the northern slope is a supporting wall, now a terrace. It is well built, 2 m thick, and about 300 m long. Apparently it belonged to a farm and was built in order to create level ground for its buildings. About 100 m west of the farmstead were found remains of a stone watchtower. On the eastern slope are quarried places and a winepress.

Pottery: Late Roman – 50%; Byzantine – 50%.

Previous surveys: None.



155. Pottery from Wadi Zeidi: 1. Jar, blk, Byz; 2-5. Jars and Jugs, brn, LR.

Site 119: 16-20/24/1

Wadi 'Asl (B)

Israel grid: 1627 2044

UTM grid: 7005 5907

Elevation: 278 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 2

Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32),
3.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1 km
distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Nov. 1978; 29 sherds

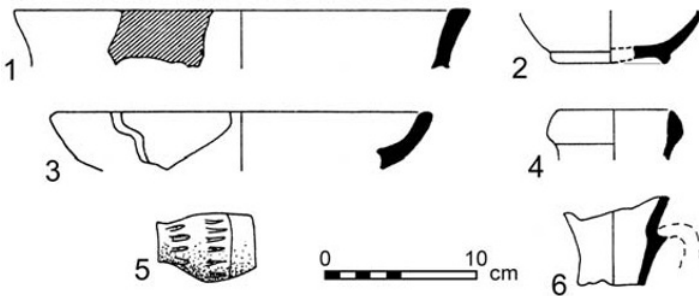
A farm on a high hilltop on the southern rim of Wadi 'Asl. It is situated in the hilly area west of the Dothan Valley, and 3 km south-south-west of Ya'bad. Near the site is a built road from Ferasin to Zibdeh.

At the edge of the range that descends eastward to the wadi there is a ruined house, apparently built in the Ottoman period. The masonry is of good quality, and it includes two vaults that support the remains of the roof. The ceilings are about 2.5 m high. The wall is built of small stones held in place with mortar and plastered. The walls contain niches for illumination with traces of soot on them.

The building is surrounded by a courtyard with a low stone fence, and contains rock-cut agricultural installations of various kinds.

Pottery: Middle Ages – 30%; Ottoman – 40%; Modern – 30%.

Previous surveys: None.



156. Pottery from Wadi 'Asl (B): 1.Bowl, green glaze, MA; 2.Jug base, wh, MA; 3.Bowl, lt, MA; 4.Jar, blk, Ott; 5.Pipe, Ott; 6.Chalice, lt, MA.

Site 120: 16-20/34/2

Khirbet Safaṭ

Israel grid: 1633 2042

UTM grid: 7011 5904

Elevation: 283 m a.s.l., 35 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: small

Area: 1.2 dunams (1200 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: uncultivated and
groves

Cisterns: 3

Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32),
3 km distant

Road: Jatt–Ta'anach (A3), next to
site

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Nov. 1978; 19 sherds

A small ruin on a round rocky hilltop in the hilly area west of the Dothan Valley. Across from it and to the south is the large site of Khirbet Samarraḥ, and between the two runs the modern road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley.

The hilltop is isolated from its environs by steep slopes descending to the east, north, and west. The only convenient way to reach it is from the south.

At the top of the hill is a rock-cut, plastered cistern, the ceiling of which has collapsed. Another cistern is now used as a *tabun* (oven) for the residents. Scant remains of walls can be seen on the southern part of the



157. Khirbet Safaṭ (on the hill); view looking west, 1978. Photo: A. Zertal.

hilltop. There are also quarried places and caves on the eastern slope. An Arab family now resides at the site.

Pottery: Middle Ages – 70%; Ottoman – 30%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 19.

Additional Bibliography: Salem 2006: site 127.



Site 121: 16-20/34/1

Khirbet Mas'ud

Israel grid: 1636 2048

UTM grid: 7014 5910

Elevation: 280 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map as ancient site

Site type: small

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa and brown forest

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 4

Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32), 2.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 800 m distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Dec. 1978; 40 sherds

A site on a rocky hilltop in the hilly area west of the Dothan Valley and 2.5 km west of the village of Ya'bad. Wadi 'Asl passes by the foot of the hill. About 500 m south of the site is the modern road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley, and to the north is the road to the villages of Zibdeh and Barṭa'ah.

At the summit are several built terraces with no traces of ancient masonry, now under cultivation. On the northern slope are openings of two large caves, and next to them is a sherd scatter. It is possible that the origin of the sherds is the caves, although there are also sherds on the top of the hill.

Porath (1968: no. 21) found here "remains of a solitary structure at the top of a rocky hilltop. Beneath the hilltop, on the north-east slope, is a small village (of former residents of Ya'bad) named Khirbet Mas'ud. Several hewn cisterns are at the top of the dome and on its slopes."

Pottery: Byzantine – 100%.

Previous surveys: Porath 1968: no. 21.

Site 122: 15-20/33/1

Khirbet Burin

Israel grid: 1535 2035	Soil quality: 7
UTM grid: 6913 5896	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 105 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: unknown
Name type: ancient, but not on map	Water source: Bir Burin (no. 149), at site
Site type: unclear	Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), at site
Area: about 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Visibility: 4
Topography: low ridge	Date of visit: 1990; 30 sherds
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	
Soil type: alluvium	

A ruin in the north-western suburbs of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, on a hilltop (E.P. 105) whose traces have been almost completely erased by modern construction work.

In the cross-sections next to the road, traces of walls, floors, etc. are visible. All other ruins are now gone. The place is mentioned as a site on the *Via Maris* in several Egyptian sources of the New Kingdom, located to the west of 'Arunah. Its Crusader name was Casal Neuf (New Village – Lyons 1971: 209). Its lands were awarded by Baibars after the victory over the Crusaders in March 1265 to “The emir Jamal al-Din Aqush al-Muhammadi al-Salihi, half of Burin; The emir Fakhr al-Din al-Tunba al-Himsi, half of Burin” (Lyons 1971: 80). On the British Survey map, Sheet VIII, the place appears as Bir Burin.

In 2001 excavations took place in the vicinity of the site and revealed scant remains of Mamluk and Ottoman period construction and a rock-cut cave (Sa'id 2005; Abu Hamid 2009). In 2002 an excavation by Sa'id (2011a) revealed five strata dating from the Early Roman to the Crusader-Ayyubid periods.

Pottery (Summary of the different surveys and excavations): Middle Bronze II; Late Bronze; Iron II; Late Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem; Middle Ages; Ottoman.

Identification: This is apparently *b-r-n* of Thutmosis III and Burim of the Shishak List (no. 33) that appear after 'Arunah (no. 32) and before Gath-Padallah (no. 34); see Chapter 2.

Previous surveys: Ne'eman (1990: site 52) notes here remains of an oil press, marble columns, and a cistern. On the north-eastern part of the hill

are remains of a large structure, built of cut *kurkar* (calcareous sandstone) stones, in which Crusader period sherds were found.

Additional Bibliography: Aharoni 1979: 50–51, 325, 327; Goren et al. 2004: 346.



Site 123: 15-20/43/1

‘Ein Beduseh

Israel grid: 1545 2036

UTM grid: 6924 5896

Elevation: 80 m a.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name type: appears on map as
ancient

Site type: sherd scatter

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: low hilltop

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: olive orchard

Cisterns: none

Water source: ‘Ein Beduseh
(no. 152), at site

Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), 500 m
distant

Visibility: 3

Date of visit: 1991; 49 sherds

A small site on a low hilltop in the hilly area east of the centre of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, with a spring bearing the same name.

No structural traces remain; only a raised place and a sherd scatter. There were apparently several houses or a small farm, but nothing is left of them.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 10%; Iron II – 25%; Persian – 10%; Hellenistic – 5%; Late Roman – 25%; Byzantine – 25%.

Previous surveys: Ne’eman (1990: site 53) notes Byzantine and Ottoman periods sherds only.

Site 124: 15-20/63/1

Khirbet Shamsin (B)

Israel grid: 1564 2031

UTM grid: 6942 5892

Elevation: 110 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: olive orchards

Cisterns: 2

Water source: 'Ein Beduseh
(no. 152), 2 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1.2 km
distant

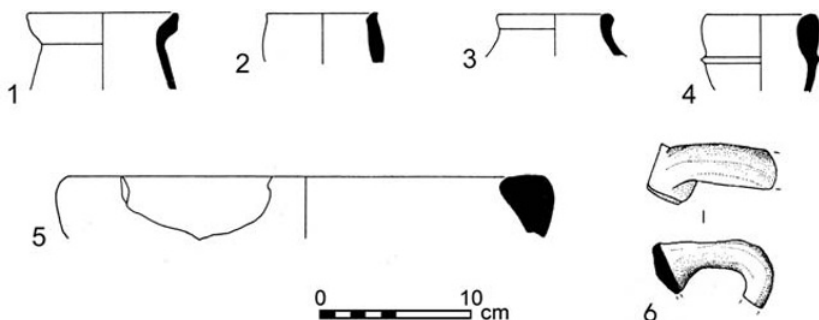
Visibility: 3

Date of visit: Nov. 1991; 30 sherds

A small site on a broad ridge, planted with olive orchards, 1 km north of Baqa esh-Sharkiyeh.

In a dense olive orchard several piles of building stones were found, evidently stones that were removed from the site. Here and there traces of walls could be seen and among them a sherd scatter. In the eastern part there are two sets of rock-cut caves:

1. The eastern cave includes an underground hall of irregular shape, containing a room 4×4 m. The approach pit into the hall is 2×5 m. The well-finished entrance is L-shaped. The entire complex is plastered, and at the entrance are structural remains.
2. The western one entrance was through a hole in the ceiling leading into a round space 4×5 m, aligned north-south. About 1 m from the entrance an arched cavern was cut.



158. Pottery from Khirbet Shamsin (B): 1.Jar, lt, Hel; 2-3.Jars, brn and lt, ER; 4.Jug, gr, Pers; 5.Basin, lt, Pers; 6.Jug handle, brn, Byz.

This was apparently a large farm, founded during Iron Age II, and existing primarily during the Persian period.

Pottery finds: Iron II – 10%; Persian – 65%; Hellenistic – 20%; Roman-Byzantine – 5%.

Previous surveys: None.



Site 125: 15-20/73/1

Khirbet Shamsin (A) (on British Survey: Kh. Shemsin)

Israel grid: 1570 2032

UTM grid: 6948 5893

Elevation: 125 m a.s.l., 12 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map as historic site

Site type: large

Area: 12.8 dunams (1.28 ha)

Topography: hilltop on ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa and brown forest

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 18

Water source: 'Ein Beduseh
(no. 152), 2.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1.3 km
distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Dec. 1982; 60 sherds

A ruin in the area of low hills between Wadi 'Asl and Wadi Jiz, about 1.3 km south-west of Qaffin, and north of the road between Baqa el-Gharbiyeh and Dothan.

It is located on a low hilltop in a mountainous range, and contains remains of 17 architectural complexes *in situ*. Most of the buildings are 8×10 m on the average, and their masonry is of especially large cut stones, with most of the entrances and lintels remaining *in situ*. No clear plan of the settlement was discerned, but it appears to belong to the 'enclosed settlement' type.

At and near the site are many cisterns, some of which have carved stone covers. Plundered burial caves and architectural pieces, such as doorposts and lintels, were found.

The British Survey described at this place "traces of ruins and a cistern" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 62).

It appears that the site belonged to the toparchy of Narbatah, and that it was mostly abandoned after the 1st century CE, as the pottery indicates.

A salvage excavation (Aizik and Peleg 2007; 2009d) was carried out in an Iron Age II burial cave, 500 m east of the site (Israel grid: 1575/2029). The cave was cut in soft chalky rock. It had a vertical entry shaft leading at its bottom to two chambers. The western chamber has been preserved intact: it is round (2.4 m diam., maximum height 0.6 m); the walls and ceiling are vaulted and the floor is rectangular (1.8×0.6 m). Three shelves were cut along the southern, northern and western walls, on which were laid the deceased in articulation. On the northern shelf the skeleton of a 30–40 year-old man was found lying on its back, laid head to the east, feet to the west. The man had been killed by at least three sword blows to the head. The left hand had been amputated, and was not buried with him; and signs of severe brutality, possibly skinning, were observed on the bones of the back. In the eastern chamber (maximum dimensions 2.1×1.4 m) was found pottery dated to the second half of the 8th century BCE.

Pottery: Iron II – 20%; Persian – 30%; Hellenistic – 15%; Early Roman – 30%; Byzantine – 5%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972: no 25; Ne'eman 1990: site 54.

Additional Bibliography: Dauphin 1998, III: site 139; Salem 2006: site 303.



Site 126: 16-20/03/1

Khirbet Hamed

Israel grid: 1602 2039

UTM grid: 6980 5901

Elevation: 190 m a.s.l., 8 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient

Site type: farm or villa

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: inner valley

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 3

Water source: Bir Isyar (no. 140),
4.7 km distant

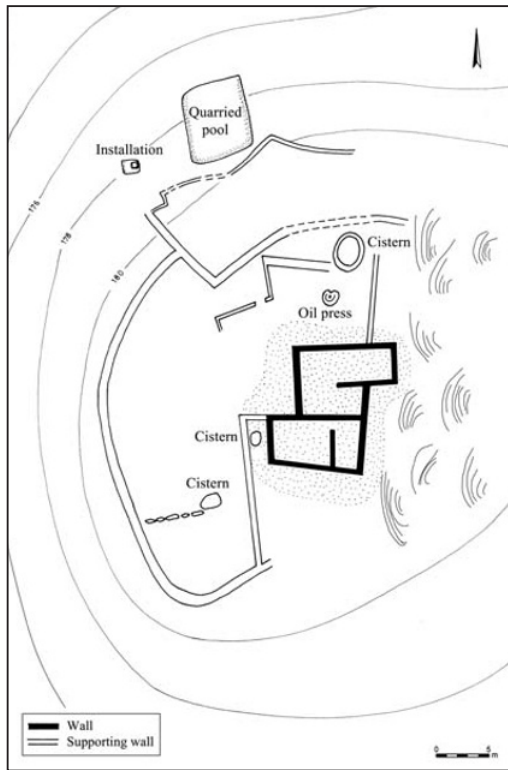
Road: Jatt–Ta'anach (A3), 800 m
distant

Visibility: 3

Date of visit: May 1997; 29 sherds

A Roman farmstead or villa on a flat rocky ridge in a valley, about 500 m north of Ferasin.

On the eastern part of the ridge are large rocky surfaces, with steep slopes descending from them westward and northward. On these sides



159. Plan of Roman villa/farm at Khirbet Hamed.

a supporting wall, 2 m high and 1.5 m thick enclosed the summit of the hill, creating a flat surface about 3 dunams (3000 sq. m) in area. On top of this was a structure of masonry of large stones, some of them cut, about 600 sq. m in area. It comprises four large rooms, some of whose entrances remain. The walls are one stone thick, about 0.5 m wide. North of the central structure is a small courtyard that was preserved with remains of an oil press. The partially broken lower crushing stone remains, as well as thresholds and bases of columns. Next to them, a round built cistern was found, whose upper diameter is about 2 m.

On the northern slope and under the supporting wall is a large quarried un-plastered pool. In addition, openings of three cisterns were found.

This site most certainly belongs to the village of adjacent Ferasin.

Pottery: Late Roman – 100%.

Previous surveys: None.



160. Photo of villa/farm at Khirbet Hamed, looking east, 1997.



161. Crushing stone *in situ* at the site. Photos: M. Einav.

Site 127: 16-20/03/2

Ferasin

Israel grid: 1602 2035	Soil quality: 7
UTM grid: 6981 5898	Cultivation: orchards (partially)
Elevation: 200 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 20
Name type: on map as historic site	Water source: Beit Sama (no. 42), 5 km distant
Site type: fortified tell	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), next to site
Area: 40 dunams (4 ha)	Visibility: 6
Topography: hilltop on mountainous height	Date of visit: 1979-81, several visits; plan - Oct. 1997; 79 sherds
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	
Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa	

A large fortified tell in the hilly area between the Dothan Valley and the Sharon. It is situated just north of the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to Dothan and about 2 km east-south-east of Qaffin. North of the site is Wadi 'Asl.

From the tell, relatively steep slopes descend to all sides except to the south-east, where there is a natural approach and an entranceway. The tell is surrounded by a high terrace, located halfway up the slope. This is apparently the wide defence wall of the site, well preserved only on the southern slope up to a height of 5 m. The wall, 3 m wide, is built of large cut stones. No clues for dating it have been found. Along most of the sections of the wall there are trenches and bunkers of a large military post dated between 1948 and 1967.

On the southern and northern slopes are more supporting walls, forming terraces 3-5 m high, with traces of structures of various periods.

On the hilltop there are two large ruined houses from the Ottoman period, each comprising several rooms and a courtyard. They are built of small stones with mortar between them, and rest upon a set of arches. The eastern of the two, 15×20 m, is almost completely destroyed, except for its central arch. The western one is larger (about 15×25 m), and rests on three arches.

In the eastern part of the hilltop are many remains of buildings. A 6 m-wide paved road leads up to the tell from the south-east, and about halfway up the slope was probably the gate. On the north-west corner of the summit surface are six white limestone columns, possibly remains of a public building. All over the summit are remains of walls, cisterns, caves

and quarried places. On the western slope is a wide area containing agricultural installations and burial caves.

The village of Ferasin has a long history as a settlement. It is mentioned in the Medieval records of the Crusader province of Caesarea (Abel 1939: 41) and in the Baibars list of 1265 as Afrasin, whose lands were given in their entirety to participants in the battle against the Crusaders: "Emir Ruchun ed-Din Khaz Turq el-Kabir es-Salihi received all the lands of Afrasin" (Lyons 1971: 80).

In the Ottoman census of 1596 it was in the Qaqun province, and contained 12 Moslem taxpayers who paid a third of their income (16750 *aqia*) including 835 *aqia* for wheat and barley, 100 for summer crops, 100 for olives and 440 for *jezia* (Hütteroth and 'Abdulfattah 1977: 137). It can be deduced that only a small portion of the village's economy relied on olives.

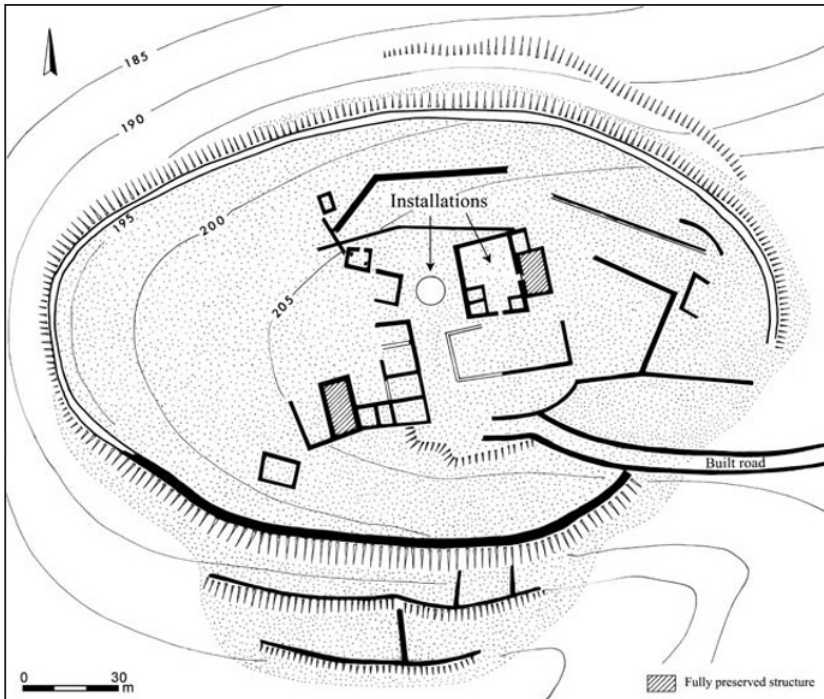
The place is mentioned by Robinson (1970, III: 124) in his journey from Ya'bad to 'Attil in 1852. In the British Survey this was recorded as a "small village on a rocky hillock, with a well to the south-east" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 47). According to the information by Grossman (1986: 345), "it was vacated of inhabitants in about 1836. It served as a fortress of the 'Abd



162. Aerial view of Ferasin, looking south-east. In background is the road from Baqa to the Dothan Valley, 1998. Photo: M. Weinberg.

el-Hadi family... registered as inhabited in all sources up to 1931". However, this is inconsistent with the British Survey evidence, according to which it was still inhabited in 1872. In 1936 it was an estate of 'Abd el-Hadi, one of the leaders of the Arab revolt, and later it was converted into a Jordanian military post.

In 1998 a salvage excavation was conducted at the site by Maharian (2000b; Israel grid 1605/2039), who discovered a mosque and a courtyard. The mosque was built in the 13th century, and continued its function during the Ottoman period. It had a square room (8×7.5 m) aligned north-south, constructed of two rows of ashlar stones in secondary use with a fill of earth and uncut stones. The walls varied in thickness from 1.1 to 1.7 m, and were preserved to a maximum height of four courses (1.5 m). Four marble columns in secondary use stood in the inner corners of the room, while the walls and the floor were coated with white mortar. The 1 m-wide doorway, of which the two lintels and the threshold stone remained, was in the northern wall. Opposite this opening was a semi-circular (diameter: 1 m) prayer niche (*mihrab*), and to its east a square niche, used perhaps for



163. Plan of fortified tell at Ferasin, 1997.

the storage of holy books (*taq*). In the upper part of the eastern wall are remains of a barrel vault. East of the opening and adjacent to the northern wall are remnants of a staircase built of ashlar in secondary use, preserved to a maximum height of 1 m, apparently leading to the roof.

The square in front of the mosque opening and along its northern wall was paved with flat stones. A rock-cut plastered cistern 11 m deep was found in it.

Pottery: Iron II – 10%; Persian – 5%, Hellenistic – 10%; Early Roman – 10%; Late Roman – 10%; Byzantine – 15%; Middle Ages – 30%; Ottoman – 10%.

Identification: This site may be *p-r-sh* of the Manasseh families (I Chr 7: 16); Avi-Yonah (1963: 128) suggests identifying it as the village of Parshai (Talmud Bavli [Babylonian Talmud] Avodah- Zarah 31), a possible proposal in light of the data; see Chapter 2.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 26.

Additional Bibliography: Beyer 1936: 38, 52; Zertal 1986: 185; Dauphin 1998, III: site 137; Salem 2006: site 82.



164. The western Ottoman structure at Ferasin; seen from the east, 1997. Photo: M. Einav.

Site 128: 16-20/04/1

Karm es-Seruj

Israel grid: 1606 2039	Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa
UTM grid: 6984 5901	Soil quality: 6
Elevation: 234 m a.s.l., 24 m a.s.a.	Cultivation: none
Name type: recognized as ancient, but not on map	Cisterns: 7
Site type: medium-sized, farm, quarry	Water source: Beit Sama (no. 42), 5 km distant
Area: 8 dunams (8000 sq. m)	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1 km distant
Topography: hilltop	Visibility: 4
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	Date of visit: Apr. 1978; 40 sherds

A site on a particularly rocky hill, dominating the area of low hills to the north of the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to Ya'bad, about 400 m north-east of Ferasin.

The entire northern part of this rocky hill served as a quarry for building stones during the time that the central site of Ferasin was in existence. At the summit of the hill and on its slopes, dozens of installations including winepresses, basins, cup-marks, and quarried places, were noted.

At the lowest part of the western slope a well-preserved structure was found, built of large field stones, and surrounded by a courtyard. In the centre of the courtyard is a rock-cut cistern. On the south-western slope is another structure, also well preserved, whose walls reach a height of three courses. Karm es-Seruj is a 'suburb' of the large settlement at nearby Ferasin. Its name (Vineyard of the Candle Oil Lamp) also indicates some ancient tradition.

Pottery: Early Roman – 10%; Late Roman – 30%; Byzantine – 60%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 129: 15-20/42/1

Baqa el-Gharbiyeh

Israel grid: 1546 2023

UTM grid: 6925 5884

Elevation: 100 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient

Site type: large village on ruin

Area: about 30 dunams (3 ha)
(ancient core)

Topography: low hill on valley
fringes

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: about 40

Water source: Bir Burin (no. 149),
1 km distant

Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), at site

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: 1990; 50 sherds

A large modern town, built on ruins which are situated in the eastern and northern parts of the town, close to the main road from Wadi 'Arah to Qalqiliyeh, a road that is also a section of the ancient *Via Maris*.

In the area of the ruin, all that is left today are a few Ottoman-style stone-built houses. There was also a traditional oil press here, which ceased operation in 1990. There are several rock-cut installations, burial caves, etc. The other ruin is Kh. Burin (see references and previous surveys).

The village is mentioned in Medieval sources. It was among the estates divided by Sultan Baibars among his faithful warriors after the defeat of the Crusaders in 1265 (Abel 1939: 42). In March 1265 the land was divided as follows: "To...The emir 'Ala' al-Din Taibars al-Zahiri, half of Baqat al-Gharbiya; The emir 'Ala' al-Din 'Ali al-Tunkuzi, half of Baqa al-Gharbiya" (Lyons 1971: 81). In the Ottoman census of 1596 it appears, in the Jebel Shami province, as a small village with five Moslem taxpayers. The village paid tax of 12000 *aqia*. Of this 6000 was for grain and 3400 was for olives (Hütteroth and 'Abduf-fattah 1977: 127). Guérin noted a relatively large accumulation of houses on a low hill, only some being ancient, with 1500 inhabitants (Guérin 1969b: 345). The British Survey describes it as: "A village of moderate size on the plain; it is very white and conspicuous, of stone and mud, with a few olives, and an orchard to the south; several wells and springs west and north. The main north road passes through it" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 152).

There have been several salvage excavations in the town.

A burial cave in the centre of the site was excavated (Badhi and Lotan 1993), containing three chambers; the opening had been blocked by a burial cover slab stone. The finds included bowls, jugs, jars, and oil lamps

from Iron Age II (10th–9th centuries BCE).

Another Iron Age II burial cave was excavated on the western edge of the ancient site (Badhi 2000; Israel grid 1546/2022). A 0.5 m opening was found blocked with a rectangular cover-stone *in situ*. At the centre of the chamber was a rectangular pit, whose northern, eastern, and southern walls were used as shelves. Close to the south-eastern corner of the chamber was an opening into another small chamber. The ceramic assemblage was dated to the 10th century BCE.

A Late Byzantine-Early Umayyad period burial cave was excavated by Sharvit (2009; Israel grid 1539/2040). The entrance, cut into hard limestone, was via a levelled square courtyard, from which one descended by steps into an oval space about 6 m across.

A Byzantine period bath-house was excavated by Badhi (2001; Israel grid 1546/2024). The surviving elements of the bath-house were the dressing room (*apodytarium*), the hot room (*caldarium*), the heating system (*hypocaust*), and the furnace (*praeformium*). The *caldarium*, only partially preserved, is situated in the northern part of the structure. It is built of limestone, plastered with reddish mortar. Vertical ceramic pipes (*tubuli*), the ends of which reached to the *hypocaust*, were attached to the inner side of the walls. The room was paved with rectangular marble slabs attached by mortar to the tiles on the *hypocaust*. At the north-western corner of the room an installation (0.55×0.4×0.4 m deep) was revealed, perhaps a basin or bathtub. Along the northern and southern walls were plastered benches. South of the *caldarium* were remains of a marble-paved room. At the end of the Byzantine period or in the Early Moslem period, when the use of the bath-house ceased, a structure of undefined plan was built over it.

A badly damaged burial cave dated to the Intermediate Bronze Age (Horowitz and Masrawa 1999; Israel grid 1548/2036) was also excavated near the ancient core of the village. Another structure from the same period was excavated on the western edge of the site (Israel grid 1539/2028). This structure may have belonged to a single-stratum settlement, to which were related the period's cemeteries, found in the vicinity ('Ad 2002).

In another salvage excavation (Mahajna 2007; Israel grid 1552/2026) remains of an oil press, quarrying, and a winepress dated to the Hellenistic or Early Roman periods were found.

Pottery (Summary of the different surveys and excavations): Intermediate Bronze; Iron II; Hellenistic; Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem; Middle Ages;

Ottoman; Modern.

Previous surveys: Ne'eman (1990: sites 58–60), mentions three sites within the village area: a ruin on a low rocky hill, in the location of the local school, with sherds from the Roman and Byzantine periods; settlement remains and cisterns, by the old mosque; and cisterns and quarried places dated to the Roman-Byzantine period.

Additional Bibliography: Beyer 1936: 48; Badhi and Bushnino 1991; Dauphin 1998, III: sites 144, 147; .



Site 130: 15-20/82/1

Khirbet Neḥalin (Umm edh-Dhiyab)

Israel grid: 1585 2028

UTM grid: 6963 5890

Elevation: 150 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: large

Area: 15 dunams (1.5 ha)

Topography: hilltop

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 15

Water source: Beit Sama (no. 42),
3.5 km distant

Road: Jatt–Ta'anach (A3), 500 m
distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Feb. 1982, Apr. 1985; 60
sherds

A large site on a hilltop, north of the road between Baqa el-Gharbiyeh and the Dothan Valley. It is situated east of the junction of the access road to the village of Qaffin and offers a view of Wadi Jiz and the Qaffin junction.

On a long narrow ridge oriented north-east–south-west, remains of about 40 structures have been preserved. The masonry is of large well-cut stones, and the walls stand to a height of 3–5 courses. They include openings, doorposts, lintels *in situ*, courtyards, many quarried places, and cisterns. All along the western part of the site is a thick terrace wall with a levelled surface, upon which some of the settlement's houses stood.

On the southern slope are many houses with doorposts and lintels *in situ*, alongside burial caves and many quarried places, and agricultural installations (winepresses and oil presses). The British Survey recorded “traces of ruins” here (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 62). For some reason the site did not appear on later maps, including those of the British Mandate

period.

This enclosed settlement was apparently connected to the toparchy of Narbatah, which was destroyed in 66 CE. The pottery points to this conclusion.

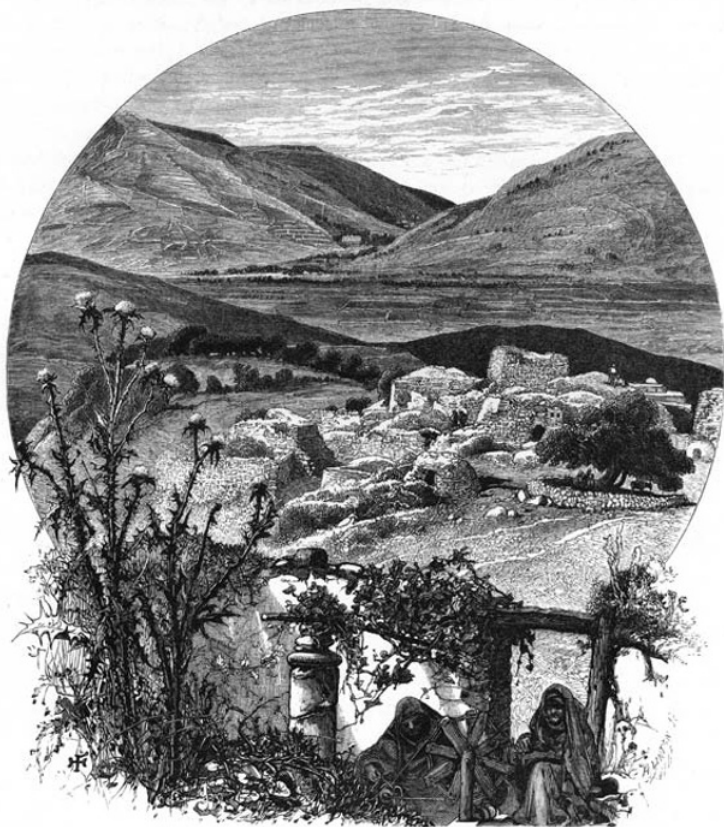
Pottery: Hellenistic – 5%; Early Roman – 80%; Late Roman – 15%.

Previous surveys: None.

CHAPTER SIX

THE DISTRICT OF NARBATAH

LANDSCAPE UNIT 25



165. Village in Samaria, etching from C. Wilson's *Picturesque Palestine* (London, 1880).

Site 131: 16-20/33/1

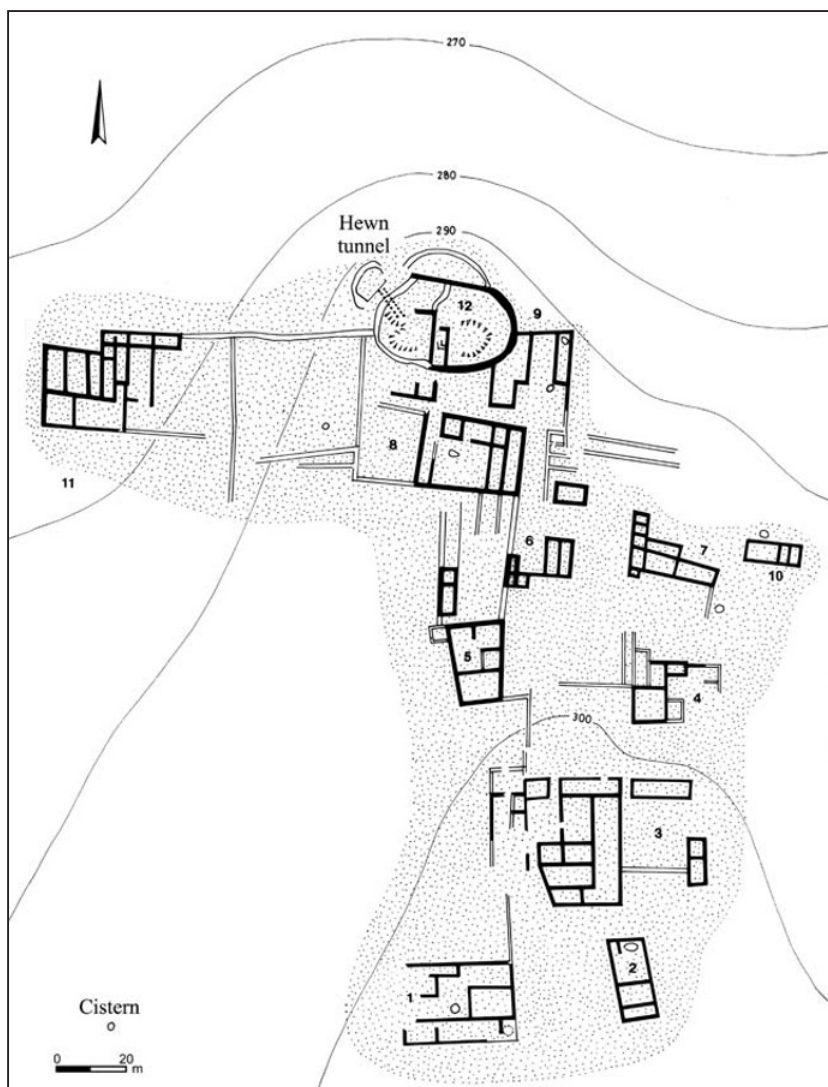
Khirbet Samarra

Israel grid: 1633 2037	Soil quality: 7
UTM grid: 7011 5900	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 295 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 15
Name type: ancient and appears on map	Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32), 3 km distant
Site type: large, dispersed ruin	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), next to site
Area: 15 dunams (1.5 ha)	Visibility: 4
Topography: saddle and hilltop	Date of visits: 1980–85; plan – May 1997; 104 sherds
Rock type: Judah group	
Soil type: terra rossa	

A large ruin on a broad saddle and a hilltop, in the hilly area west of the Dothan Valley. From the hilltop, slopes descend to the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley: the saddle extends southward to the same hilltop.

The site, composed of complexes of courtyard-houses on the saddle and a central complex on the hilltop, was well-planned. A series of wide terraces were created over the entire area, upon which the houses stand. The saddle area contains 12 complexes of courtyard houses, whose description is as follows:

1. Southern complex, about 20×25 m. A courtyard house with rooms and a pit in the centre.
2. A three-roomed long structure with a cistern, apparently from a later period (Middle Ages?).
3. The largest complex, 40×80 m, with many rooms around inner courtyards. The eastern part is now destroyed, but apparently the complex was larger than the preserved remains, and extended eastward.
- 4-7, 10. Small complexes in the centre of the site.
8. A large courtyard-house south of the hilltop, 20×50 m, with a cistern in the centre.
9. A stepped structure on the slope east of the hilltop, and apparently connected to it.
11. An especially large, isolated complex on a moderate slope, 50 m west of the hilltop.
12. This complex is on the hilltop itself. The east side is surrounded by a circular wall, 2 m thick and about 20 m in diameter. In its centre is a



166. Plan of the Roman site at Khirbet Samarra, 1997. The place includes sophisticated courtyard houses; the centre is on the low summit to the north.

building whose foundations are in a large quarried depression. In the western half of the hilltop there is a new wall, and it is difficult to distinguish the ancient remains. On the western slope is a small courtyard around the opening of a 20 m long tunnel that leads under the hilltop. This last was only partially investigated.

The masonry of the complexes is especially good, of large, drafted stones. The place was a wealthy settlement, with high quality construction. The complexes stand at a considerable distances from each other, and there may have been a street connecting them. A considerable sherds scatter was found.

The British Survey notes only “traces of ruins and caves” (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 62). Gophna and Porath (1972: no. 27) describe “a small ruin on top of a ridge. Its area is about 2 dunams. On the surface of the ruin remains of 8 structures were discerned; building is with cut stones without mortar”.

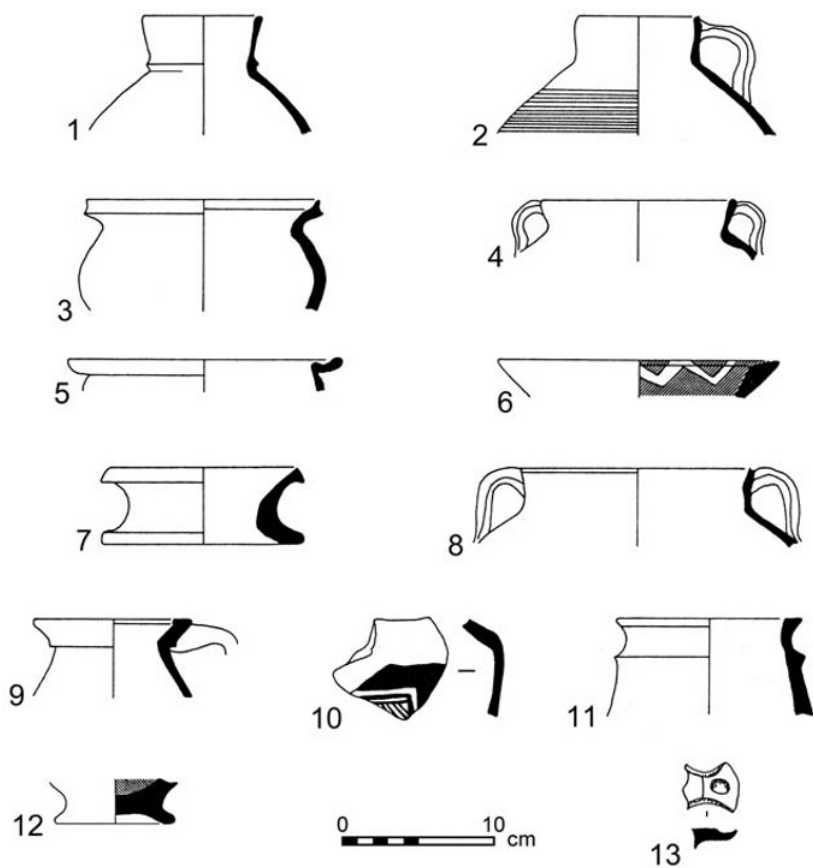
Pottery: At the north-west: scattered sherds from Persian and Hellenistic periods. At the site: Roman – 80%; Early Moslem–Middle Ages – 20% (in south part of site only).

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 27; Zertal 1984: no. 25.

Additional Bibliography: Dauphin 1998, III: site 135; Salem 2006: site 292.



167. Khirbet Samarraḥ, viewed from west. The site is on the rocky summit in centre. Photo: A. Zertal, 1978.



168. Pottery from Khirbet Samarra: 1. Jar, lt, Rom; 2. Pilgrim flask, lt, ER; 3. Bowl, lt brn, ER; 4. CP, brn, LR; 5. Bowl, lt brn, ER; 6. Bowl, brn-yel glaze, MA; 7. Stand, rd, ER; 8. CP, brn, ER; 9. Jug, brn, Rom; 10. Jar, brn on beige, Mam (MA); 11. Jar, dk brn, LR; 12. Jug base, yel, MA; 13. Lamp, pk, ER.

Site 132: 15-20/92/1

Jebel Taleb (A)

Israel grid: 1594 2026	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 6972 5888	Cultivation: orchards
Elevation: 170 m a.s.l., 25 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 2
Name type: on map, but not as historic site	Water source: Beit Sama (no. 42), 3.5 km distant
Site type: stones mound	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), next to site
Area: 1.4 dunams (1400 sq. m)	Visibility: 5
Topography: hilltop	Date of visit: Feb. 1978, June 1997;
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	29 sherds
Soil type: rendzina	

A small site on an isolated hilltop in the hilly area south of the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley, and about 1.3 km south-west of Ferasin. North of the hill runs the Roman road from Caesarea to Ginai.

On the summit there is a very large mound of stones, about 12×25 m in diameter and about 4 m high. Possibly it covers some sort of structure. Around it is a sherd scatter, with no other traces of building. North of it is a rock-cut cave.

The Emergency Survey describes "remains of a fort (?), on the top of a hill. Three small stone mounds next to each other. Rock quarrying to the west. Opening of a burial cave beneath the south-western mound. Pottery: Israelite Period I (a few fragments) and Persian (main part of find)" (Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 31).

In our last visit (1997) the site had been totally dismantled in order to plant an olive grove.

Pottery: Iron I – 60%; Persian – 40%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 31.

Additional surveys: Ne'eman 1990: site 62 (notes here also Byzantine sherds).

Additional Bibliography: Zertal 1986: 184; Salem 2006: site 262.

Site 133: 15-20/92/2

Jebel Taleb (B)

Israel grid: 1597 2026	Soil quality: 5
UTM grid: 6975 5888	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 140 m a.s.l., 20 m b.s.a.	Cisterns: 1
Name type: nearest place	Water source: Beit Sama (no. 42), 3.5 km distant
Site type: enclosure	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 300 m distant
Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)	Visibility: 3
Topography: ravine	Date of visit: Feb. 1978; 19 sherds
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	
Soil type: terra rossa	

A small site in the hilly area north of Wadi Jiz, and south of the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley. It is situated on a low slope that descends southward to Wadi Jiz.

There is a square structure resembling an enclosure or courtyard, about 25×25 m. It is built of large stones, and the surrounding wall is about 1 m thick (2 rows of stones). The enclosure is 2 to 3 courses high; its built opening is on the south-eastern side.

The enclosure, in its masonry and dimensions, resembles enclosures found and published in the volume on Eastern Manasseh (Zertal 2008a: sites 126, 130, 242 and many others).

Pottery: Early Roman – 100%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 134: 16-20/42/1

Jebel Qurein

Israel grid: 1640 2023	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7018 5886	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 300 m a.s.l., 150 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name type: nearest place	Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32),
Site type: fort	3.5 km distant
Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)	Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 300 m
Topography: high summit	distant
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	Visibility: 8
Soil type: terra rossa	Date of visit: Feb. 1979; 20 sherds

A fort on a high summit of Jebel Qurein south of and above the channel of Wadi Jiz and in the hilly area west of the Dothan Valley. South of it runs the Roman road from Narbatah to the Dothan Valley.

There is a large stone mound, inside which are traces of building and parts of walls. Presumably this site was built to guard the road, but it is difficult to discern the plan.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 20%; Early Roman – 80%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 31.



Site 135: 16-20/42/2

Khirbet el-'Uqdeh

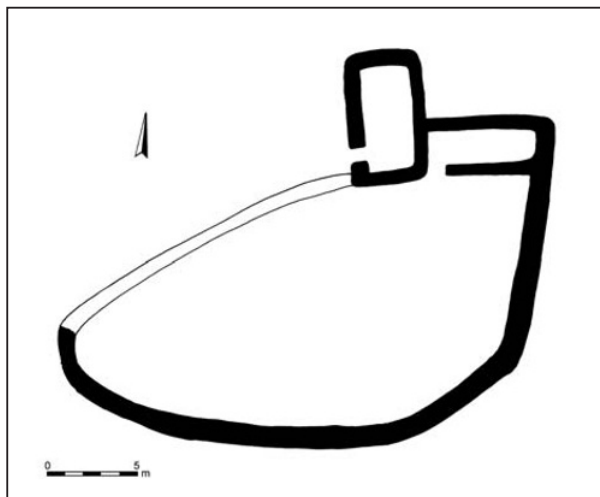
Israel grid: 1648 2030	Soil quality: 5
UTM grid: 7026 5893	Cultivation: field crops
Elevation: 270 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name type: ancient and on map	Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32),
Site type: structure	2.7 km distant
Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)	Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 500 m
Topography: height	distant
Rock type: Judah group	Visibility: 4
Soil type: terra rossa	Date of visit: Oct. 1997; 5 sherds

A farmstead on the el-'Uqdeh plateau north of Wadi Jiz, about 3 km southwest of Ya'bed. The rocky ridge is partially cultivated. A pine forest has been planted on its eastern and northern sides.

The site is at the edge of a ridge facing Jebel Qurein, from which the channels of Wadi Jiz can be seen. The structure comprises two long rooms, each about 3×5 m, connected to each other, with a courtyard. The walls



169. The farmhouse structure at Khirbet el-'Uqdeh, 1998.



170. Plan of the farmhouse at Khirbet el-'Uqdeh.

are about 1.2 m wide, and the stones are local, with no mortar. Each of the rooms has a built entrance, and small windows were also found. The bow-shaped courtyard is south of and connected to the rooms. Its northern part was dismantled.

It seems that the structure was abandoned for unknown reasons before it was inhabited. The stones lack patina, and thus it seems that it was built only a few decades ago. It can be dated to the 20th century.

Another farmstead was found at the eastern edge of the range, on the upper part of the slope. A structure and a courtyard that were in use for a short time were noted.

Pottery: Ottoman – 20%; Modern – 80%.

Previous surveys: None.



Site 136: 16-20/52/1

El-Mughur

Israel grid: 1657 2026

UTM grid: 7035 5888

Elevation: 276 m a.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: military camp or inn

Area: 4 dunams (4000 sq. m)

Topography: edge of ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 2

Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32),
2.8 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 500 m
distant

Visibility: 3

Date of visits: Feb., May 1979, June
1997; 32 sherds

A small site on a broad ridge, in the hilly area south of the Dothan Valley, and about 750 m south-west of the settlement of Mevo Dothan. North of the site is Wadi Jiz, and east of it is Wadi Salem. Slightly east of this site is Khirbet el-Qureinat (Site 137).

The place includes a wide square well-built courtyard, the sides of which are about 40 m long. Its three wings (northern, western, and eastern; the southern side did not survive) are each built of two parallel walls, 1.1 m thick and with 5–6 m between them. Between the parallel walls are perpendicular walls, which apparently divided the space into rooms. A terrace wall was later built on the courtyard, and the semi-enclosed part

of the site became a cultivated field. Apparently the southern wing was dismantled for cultivation.

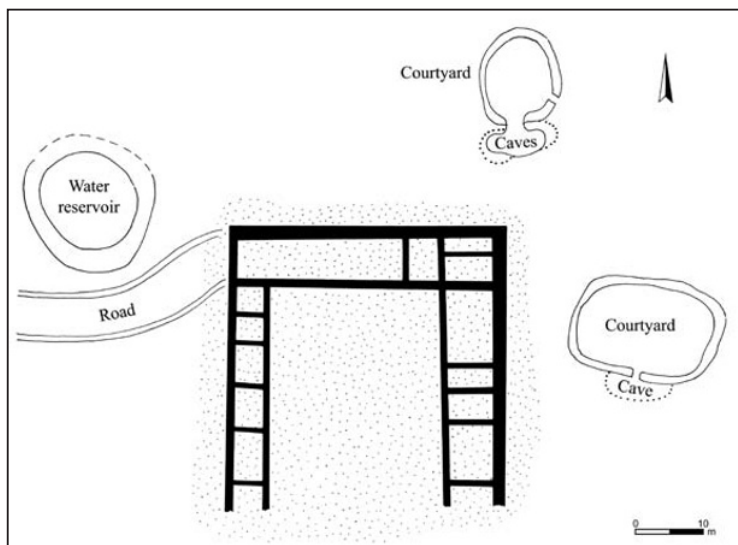
To the west of the courtyard is a water reservoir, 15 m in diameter, consisting of a large, pit with construction around it. A built road (?) extends from the site westwards.

To the north and east of the courtyard are two large caves (this is the source of the site's name, which means 'The Caves') with stone-built courtyards in front of their entrances. Next to the caves are several carved rocks and architectural items (lintels, etc.). No sherds were found near the courtyards.

The site appears to have been a Roman military camp, but it is also possible that it served a different function. If it was indeed a camp, it may be linked by association with the siege of nearby Narbatah. In a discussion of the road from Caesarea to Ginai (Zertal 1986) it was proposed that the road passed through Wadi Jiz, but possibly this branch of the road ascended to the el-Mughur ridge in the direction of the Dothan Valley in some other place.

Pottery: Late Roman – 100%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 32.



171. Plan of the Roman camp (?) at el-Mughur, 1998. The water reservoir may have belonged to the camp; the courtyards to the east and north-east may be from a later period (Medieval?).

Site 137: 16-20/62/1

Khirbet el-Qureinat

Israel grid: 1665 2024

UTM grid: 7043 5887

Elevation: 326 m a.s.l., 32 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: large ruin on tell

Area: 11 dunams (1.1 ha)

Topography: hilltop on
mountainous height

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: groves (partial)

Cisterns: 4

Water source: Bir Jamal (no. 32),
3 km distant

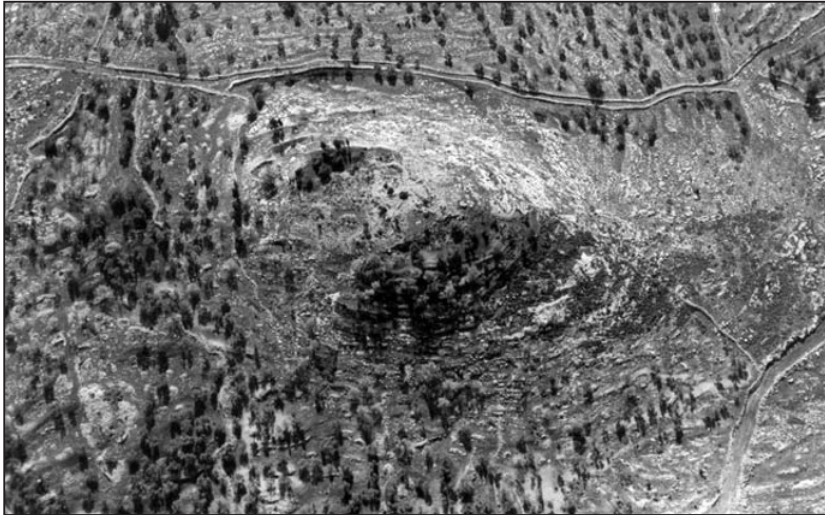
Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 2 km
distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visits: April, Aug. 1978; plan
– 1998; 60 sherds

A site on a broad hilltop, in the area of low hills south-west of Dothan Valley, about 2.5 km north-west of the village of 'Arrabeh. In the southern part a built path goes from this village to Ya'bad, and north of the site is Wadi Salem, which merges into Wadi Jiz.

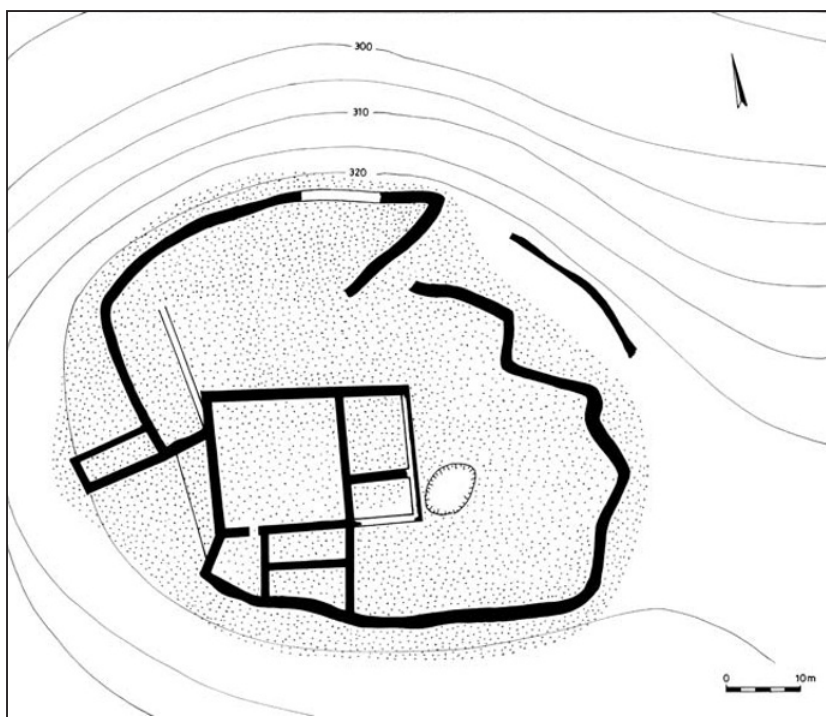
Steep slopes to the east, north, and west isolate this site from its environs. It was conveniently approachable from the south, where it is attached to the range.



172. Aerial photo of Khirbet el-Qureinat, looking south, 1998. Photo: M. Weinberg. The built path above the site leads to 'Arrabeh (left) and to Wadi Jiz (right).



173. Khirbet el-Qureinat, looking southwards. 1980. Photo: A. Zertal.



174. Plan of the site at Khirbet el-Qureinat, 1998.

The eastern part now has an olive grove on it. In the western part many structural remains are preserved *in situ*: houses and courtyards, some of which have an easily discernible plan. The masonry is of large, uncut field stones, and some of the walls are now covered with piles of cleared stones. In the northern part of the site, inside several courtyards, standing monoliths have been preserved. On the northern slope several cave openings were found, some of which were used for burial.

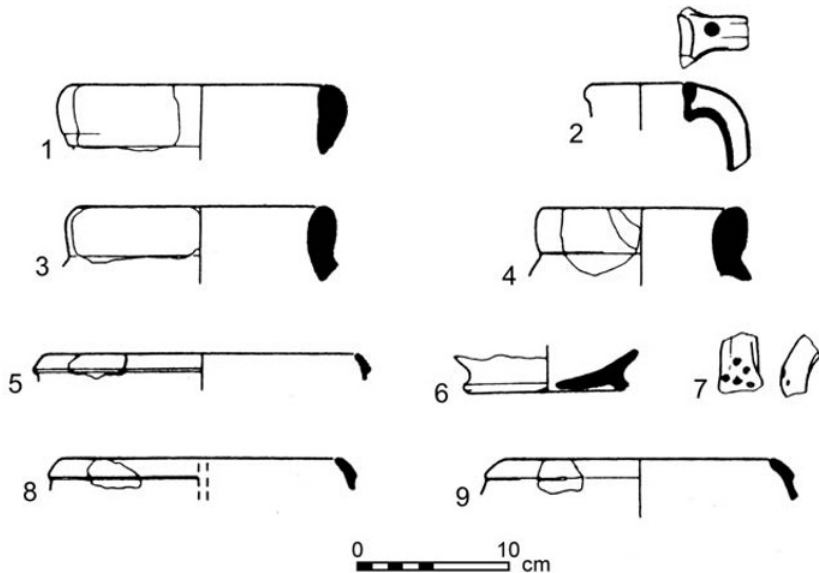
Two fortification lines were detected: the upper one encloses the present village, which seems to have been established during the Persian period; the lower one, less well preserved, surrounds it at half of the height of the slope. The latter may have been built in the Iron Age.

The sherd scatter indicates that the present buildings were built during the Persian period; but the basic outline (including the lower wall) suggests that most of the fortification line and structures are from the Iron Age.

Pottery: Iron I – 20%; Iron II – 5%; Iron III – 5%; Persian – 70%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 33.

Additional Bibliography: Salem 2006: site 263.



175. Pottery from Khirbet el-Qureinat: 1. Pithos, IA I; 2. Perforated jug handle, brn, IA I; 3-4. Pithoi, yel, IA I; 5, 8-9. CP, dk, IA I; 6. Bowl base, brn, IA I; 7. Handle with perforated dec, brn, IA I.

Site 138: 15-20/40/1

Jatt (East)

Israel grid: 1548 2021

UTM grid: 6926 5861

Elevation: 55 m a.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: large

Area: 10 dunams (1 ha)

Topography: low ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: almond plantation

Cisterns: none

Water source: Bir Zeitah (no. 150),
1.2 km distant

Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), next to
site

Visibility: 5

Date of visits: Sept. 1990; 51 sherds

A large site on the eastern ridge of Jatt, just east of it and the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to Tulkarm. From the site is a good view of the Rimón Valley (Sahel Rummaneh) that extends from Jatt to the range of 'Illar.

There are many sherds over the entire area, presently cultivated and planted. On the northern slope are many agricultural installations and the openings of two caves. Here and there are building stones and terraces made of cleared stones. On the southern slope an abandoned structure was found, built of cut stones and plastered. It has a domed roof, and in the large room is a *mihrab* oriented toward Mecca. This seems to be a tomb or abandoned mosque from the Ottoman period.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 22%; Early Roman – 28%; Late Roman – 15%; Byzantine – 15%; Early Moslem – 20%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 139: 15-20/81/1

En-Nazleh el-Gharbiyeh

Israel grid: 1581 2010	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 6960 5871	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 131 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 28
Name type: ancient	Water source: Bir Sama (no. 42), 1.7 km distant
Site type: village on ruin	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1.5 km distant
Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Visibility: 5
Topography: hilltop	Date of visit: 1986
Rock type: 'Avdat group	
Soil type: terra rossa	

A small village on a low hilltop on the fringes of Rummaneh near Nahal Hadera (wadi Jiz). It is situated in the northern part of the valley, east of Jatt and about 1.5 km south-east of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh.

In the centre of the village are houses 100–150 years old, with quarried places, installations, and cisterns. According to Grossman (1986: 345) it was founded after the middle of the 19th century CE by people from Şeida. It appears in the British Survey as Nuzlet et-Tinat: “a little hamlet with fig trees, and a well to the west on low ground. It has caves opposite it on the south.” (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 153).

South-west of the village is a Sheikh's tomb named esh-Sheikh Khalil (Israel grid 1579/2006), on top of a hill. The walls of the rectangular structure are built of drafted stones in secondary use, and it has a dome. North of the tomb is a blocked up bell-shaped cistern. Byzantine period sherds were collected. Ne'eman (1990: site 69) noted dismantled ancient structures and Roman-Byzantine sherds.

Pottery (Summary of the different surveys and excavations): Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem; Middle Ages; Ottoman.

Previous surveys: Ne'eman 1990: site 68.

Additional Bibliography: Dauphin 1998, III: site 153.

Site 140: 15-20/91/1

En-Nazleh el-Wusta

Israel grid: 1593 2016

UTM grid: 6971 5877

Elevation: 150 m a.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient and on map

Site type: small village on ruin

Area: about 10 dunams (1 ha)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: about 30

Water source: Bir Sama (no. 42),
2.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1 km
distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: 1997; 20 sherds

A small village on a ridge through which a road to en-Nazleh el-Gharbiyeh passes. A few houses dating from the Ottoman period are on a small ridge south-west of Khallet 'Aqbat Yunes.

It can be assumed that the village was founded together with en-Nazleh esh-Sharqiyeh and el-Gharbiyeh. There are a few quarried places and burial caves at the site, but it is not clear whether they belong to the village. In the British Survey it is described as: "yet smaller [in comparison to Nuzlet esh Sharqiyeh, A.Z.], on a spur with a few trees" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 153).

Pottery: Ottoman – 100%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 141: 15-20/92/3

El-Qaşr

Israel grid: 1596 2021	Cultivation: groves
UTM grid: 6974 5882	Cisterns: none
Elevation: 180 m a.s.l., 60 m a.s.a.	Water source: Bir Sama (no. 42), 3 km distant
Name type: ancient, but not on map	Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1 km distant
Site type: citadel or enclosure	Visibility: 6
Area: 4.5 dunams (4500 sq. m)	Date of visit: 1978–1980; plan – June 1997; 19 sherds
Topography: edge of ridge	
Rock type: Mount Scopus group	
Soil type: rendzina	
Soil quality: 5	

A fortified enclosure situated at the edge of the ridge of Khirbet el-Qaşur, west of the village of Nazleh esh-Sharqiyeh, and in the hilly area between the Sharon and the Dothan Valley. The ridge, oriented north-west–south-east, begins at the village and ends on the slope descending northward to the deep Wadi Jiz. From the site is a view of the wadi channel and the hills to its north.

The 2 m-thick wall of the rectangular enclosure, 60 m long on the northern and southern sides, and 67.5 m long on the eastern and western sides, is built of drafted, smoothed ashlar. The masonry is of headers and stretchers. The average size of the ashlar is about 2 m long, 0.6 m wide and 0.8 m high. There are two rows of stones (inside and out) with a filling between them. In most of the wall sections one course of stones remains, but on the south side there are two and even three courses.

In each of the four corners is a small, square tower, each originally about 4×4 m. On the east and west sides there are 4 m-square projections from the wall. On the northern and southern sides there are openings. On the northern opening, which is well preserved and about 1 m wide, is a device for closing the door and a bolt hole.

Near the south-eastern and south-western corners there are cistern openings, which were originally inside the towers. In the inner part of the site, no structures were found, apart from three rock-cut winepresses. The area inside is exposed bedrock with patches of soil and a few sherds. Another rock-cut winepress was found outside the enclosure, close to the eastern wall. Apparently these winepresses post-date the enclosure itself.

In the small wadi beneath and to the west of the site (Khallet 'Aqbat

Yunes) is a well cut in the rock, 5 m in diameter and about 5 m deep (reaching down to the alluvium layer). The well is built of ashlar similar to those of the enclosure, and it is possible that the well and enclosure comprised one complex.

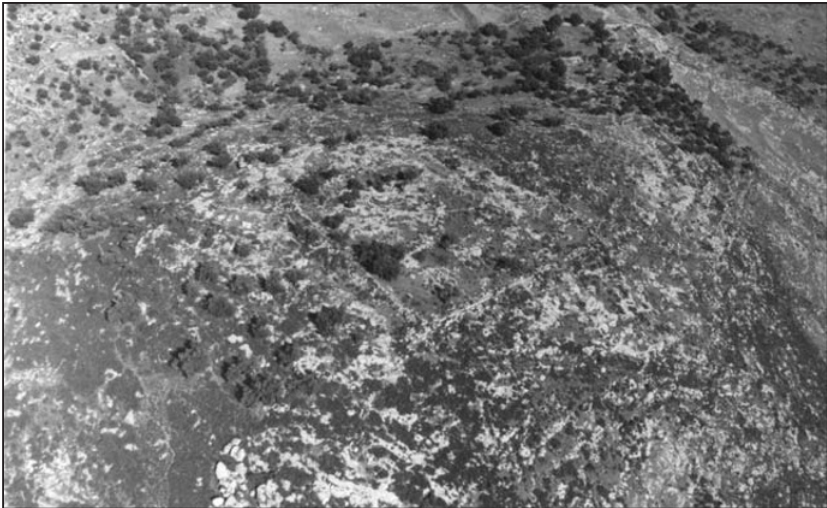
In the Emergency Survey is the description: “remains of a rectangular citadel 63.5×69.75 m in size. It is built of ashlar 40×120×70 cm on the average, built in header and stretcher style. The walls are built of stones inside and out, with a filling of stone and mortar between them, and are preserved up to 3 courses high. The walls are 1.2 m wide. Six towers protrude outwards, 4 corner towers and a tower in the middle of the long wall. No building traces were found inside the citadel. Pottery: Roman-Byzantine (a few ribbed sherds).” (Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 32).

It appears that the construction of the citadel was not completed, as at ‘Iraq Abu Hashish (A) in the desert fringe of Manasseh (Zertal 2008a: site 248). The site might have had a military function in the defence of the passage through Wadi Jiz.

Pottery: Early Roman – 100%.

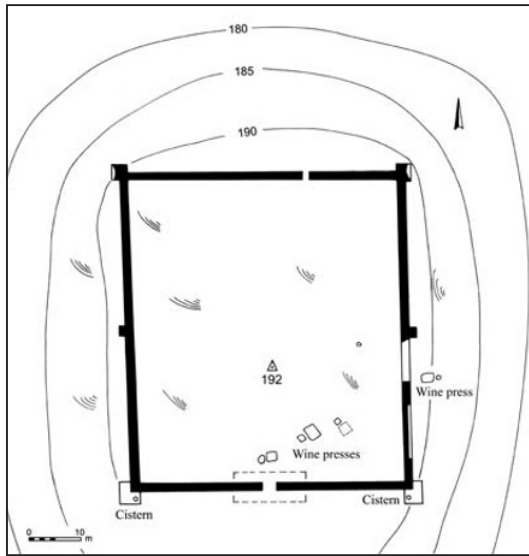
Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 32; Ne’eman 1990: site 63.

Additional Bibliography: Dauphin 1998, III: site 149; Salem 2006: site 370.



176. Bird's-eye view of the abandoned citadel of el-Qaşr, looking south, 1998.

Photo: M. Weinberg.



177. Plan of the abandoned citadel at el-Qaşr, 1997.



Site 142: 15-20/61/1

Baqa esh-Sharqiyeh

Israel grid: 1568 2019

UTM grid: 6947 5880

Elevation: 130 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient

Site type: village on ruin

Area: about 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)
(ancient core)

Topography: height

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: about 20

Water source: Bir Sama (no. 42),
3 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), near site

Visibility: 5

Date of visit: 1980-1987; no sherds
counted

A medium-sized village on a plateau, about 1.5 km east-south-east of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh. It is situated on the main road to the Dothan Valley (road A3), and is surrounded by ancient olive groves.

The ancient core includes houses with courtyards, built of stones and plastered with mud. Most of these houses are falling apart. There are also

burial caves, installations, and cistern openings.

The village is mentioned in the Crusader period. Its lands were awarded to the warriors of Baibars in 1265 after the victory over the Crusaders (Abel 1939: 41). In the 1596 census there were 35 Moslem taxpayers who paid tax of 14000 *aqia* in total on a quarter of their harvest. Of this, 7240 was for wheat and barley, 2760 for summer crops and vegetables, and 1500 for olives (Hütteroth and 'Abdulfattah 1977: 159).

According to Grossman (1986: 345) the village may have been abandoned after the 16th century CE and then settled by residents from Şeida.

Pottery (Summary of the different surveys): Hellenistic; Early and Late Roman; Byzantine; Middle Ages.

Previous surveys: Ne'eman 1990: site 64.

Additional Bibliography: Beyer 1936: 57.



Site 143: 15-20/61/1

Khirbet el-Quşur (on British Survey map: Khirbet el-Ikrein)

Israel grid: 1598 2018

UTM grid: 6977 5880

Elevation: 180 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient

Site type: large

Area: 11 dunams (1.1 ha)

Topography: ridge on mountainous height

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 8

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43), 2.7 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1.2 km distant

Visibility: 6

Date of visit: 1978-1979 several visits; June 1997; 89 sherds

A large site just west of Nazleh esh-Sharqiyeh, and south of and above Wadi Jiz. North of it, beyond the wadi, runs the road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley. The ruin is situated on a broad ridge, whose steep slopes descend to the east and west. It is easily approachable only from the south-east, and a road descends from it to el-Qaşr (Site 141).

On the place are many structural remains *in situ*, mostly courtyard houses including cisterns. The masonry is good, of worked field stones and ashlar. The slopes are terraced, with structural remains. There are many

installations and caves in and around the site.

During a second visit we were told by the local residents that there are fairly extensive underground systems, including caves, rooms, and passageways. Several partial visits were made, but a plan was not drawn up.

In the British Survey, under the name Khurbet Ikhrein, the site appears as “heaps of stones” (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 60). In the Emergency survey it is described: “a ruin upon a ridge, about 2 dunams in area. The ruin has been partially cleared of stones and is cultivated. Some of the structures remain at the site in the form of piles of stones, and stones of other buildings are integrated in the cultivation terraces. An upper crushing stone of an oil press was found” (Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 35).

Pottery: Byzantine – 30%; Early Moslem – 30%; Middle Ages – 40%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972: no. 35; Ne’eman 1990: site 65.

Additional Bibliography: Salem 2006: site 264.



178. The site at Khirbet Quşur, facing south, 1982. Photo: A. Zertal.

Site 144: 16-20/02/1

En-Nazleh esh-Sharqiyeh

Israel grid: 1603 2019

UTM grid: 6981 5881

Elevation: 200 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, and appears on map

Site type: Arab village on ruin

Area: about 30 dunams (3 ha)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: about 60

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43), 2.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 1.2 km distant

Visibility: 6

Date of visit: 1980–1990 several visits; 30 sherds

A medium-sized village on a western ridge of Wadi Jiz, just east of Khirbet Quşur. There is a view of the Şeida range to the south and of the Umm el-Faḥm range to the north.

In the village is a small ancient core containing several houses built in Ottoman style, some with domes. This core is situated in the western part of the village, which contains many quarried places, ancient cisterns, and burial caves in secondary use (particularly on the northern slope).



179. En-Nazleh esh-Sharqiyeh, looking east, 1990.

The place does not appear in Baibars' list, the 1596 census, or Guérin. In the British Survey, it appears as: "a little hamlet with a well on the south, and a few olives. It stands on high ground and has a palm-tree near" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 153).

Pottery: Middle Ages – 36%; Ottoman – 40%; Modern – 24%.

Previous surveys: None.



Site 145: 16-20/22/1

El-Kuleileh

Israel grid: 1622 2017

UTM grid: 7000 5879

Elevation: 213 m a.s.l., 60 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: large structure

Area: about 2 dunams (200 sq. m)

Topography: high hilltop

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 1

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
2.5 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), at site

Visibility: 6

Date of visit: 1978, 1990 and more;
50 sherds

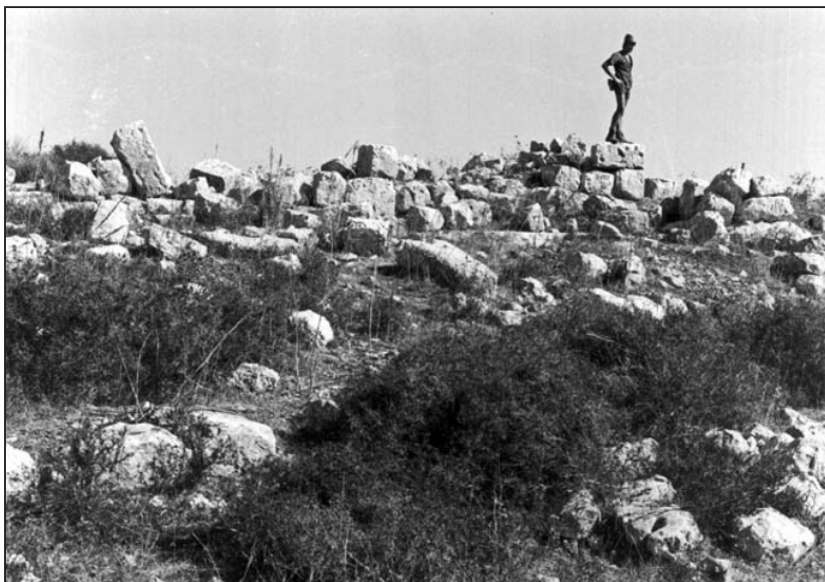
A site on a high rocky hilltop, at the edge of a ridge descending from the area of Khirbet Samarra to Wadi Jiz. A branch of the Roman road from Caesarea to Ginae passed over this ridge and descended to Narbatah. Traces of this road are visible today along the new unpaved road.

On the top of the hill is a large structure, about 30×35 m, comprising two wings and a large courtyard in the centre. The structure's masonry is of large carved stones, with some of the doorposts and lintels are still *in situ*. North of the site is an exposed rocky slope upon which are rock-cut installations, and on a saddle to the north-east is siege camp no. 4 (see Khirbet el-Ḥamam–Narbatah, Site 146).

This place may be connected with the siege of Narbatah (for details see Zertal 1995), and possibly one of the military headquarters of the Roman army. This may also have been a large structure (farmhouse or something similar) near the city of Narbatah. The ascription of a military function to the site is based on its location and dominance of the circumvallation and the camps.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 20%; Early Roman – 80%.

Previous surveys: None.



180. Remains of the structure at el-Kuleileh, 1984. The good masonry indicates a public building. The structure may be connected with the siege works.



Site 146: 16-20/21/2

Khirbet el-Ḥamam (in British Survey: el-Khurab)

Israel grid: 1627 2016

UTM grid: 7006 5878

Elevation: 247 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.

Name type: appears on map as an ancient site

Site type: fortified tell

Area: about 100 dunams (10 ha)

Topography: mountainous height

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: olive grove

Cisterns: about 50

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43), 2.5 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), at site

Visibility: 5

Date of visit: 1978–1984; several visits and excavation seasons

A fortified tell on two hilltops in the hills west of the Dothan Valley, and above the deep channel of Wadi Jiz. From the fortified northern hilltop, deep slopes descend to the east, north and west. Between the two hilltops is a saddle on which a Roman siege ramp has been excavated. From the site is a limited view of the valley to its west, el-Mughraqah, of the surrounding hills, and of the two adjacent sites, el-Kuleileh and el-Birkeh. Excavations were conducted here in 1980–1981 and 1984, directed by A. Zertal.

The site is comprised of five parts: (1) the northern tell (Ḥamam A); (2) the southern hilltop (Ḥamam B); (3) the water system; (4) the approach road; and (5) the siege array:

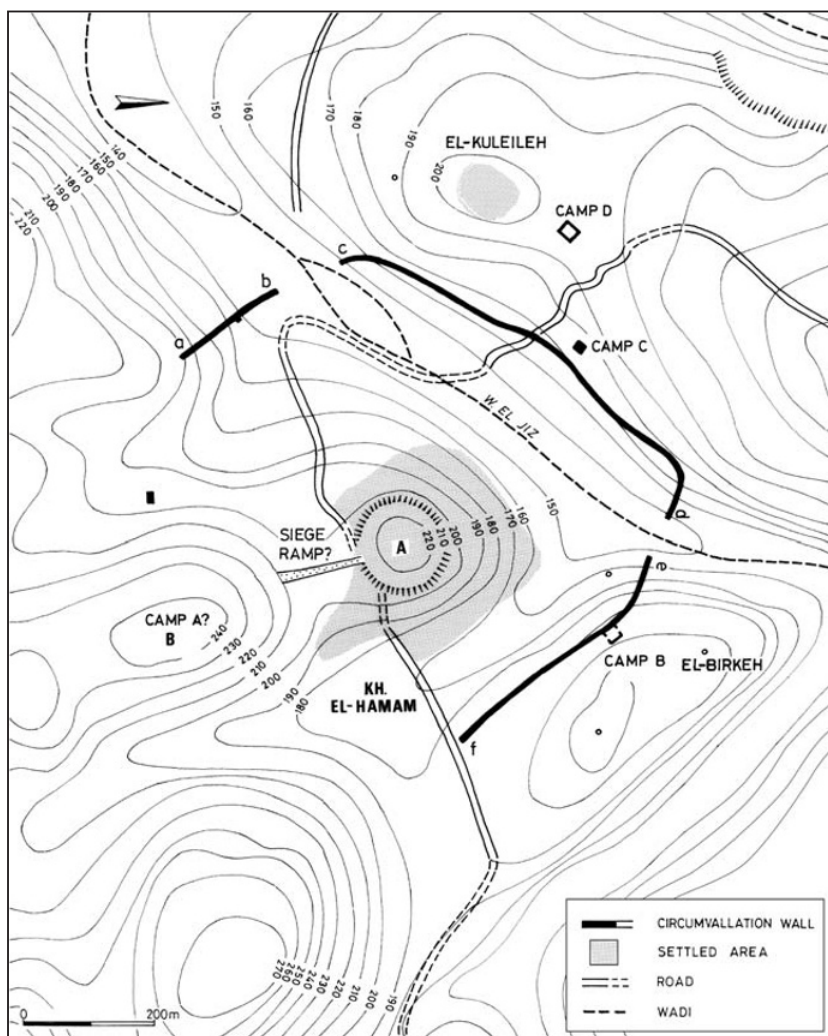
(1) **The northern tell** (Ḥamam A): Excavated in 1981 and 1984. The hilltop, with an area of 30 dunams (3 ha), is well protected by two thick city-walls: one, an Iron Age wall, of which only a few parts were excavated in the southern section, and above it a Hellenistic-Herodian wall. The former is about 3 m wide, and appears as a step surrounding the upper part of the tell. During the Late Hellenistic period the early wall became a support wall and a 'ring road', upon which an approach road to the entrance gate on the northern side of the site was located. The upper wall is about 5 m wide, with a saw-tooth design, and its masonry is a combination of ashlar on the corners and field stones in the centre of the various sections. The main entrance to the site was on the northern part, so that a person



181. Khirbet el-Ḥamam, viewed from the west, 1978. Beneath the tell is Wadi Jiz.
Photo: A. Zertal.

approaching the city would have had to use the 'ring road' in order to enter. The location of the main gate of the Iron Age has not been found.

The hilltop itself was densely built up. On the upper part is a central building, about 8×10 m, built of drafted Hellenistic style stones. In 1984 a dwelling quarter was excavated west of this central building. A street oriented east-west and descending toward the city wall was uncovered here. Next to it two dwelling complexes were excavated. The southern one



182. The plan of the site and siege of Khirbet el-Hamam, 1984.

consisted of a courtyard-house with several rooms, a cellar and a *mikveh*. The construction was of good quality, of cut field stones. The structure was built in the Late Hellenistic period and lasted until the abandonment of the city between 66 and 70 CE.

In the southern part of the hilltop a 10 m-wide central section was excavated. It began at the siege rampart, and ascended to the 'ring road'. From here, the section exposed the Iron Age wall and a large public structure, about 25×30 m in the eastern part. The structure stood outside of the Hellenistic city wall.

(2) **The southern hilltop (Ḥamam B):** This hill is higher and larger than Hamam A, and overlooks the northern hilltop. It has not been excavated, but many structural remains were found on it, and apparently it was part of the city during the peak of its expansion in the 1st century CE. On the western slope a large built pool was found, and on the southern part of the hilltop there was a structure with a courtyard and many rooms. These were apparently from the Middle Ages. On the northern slope, overlooking Ḥamam A, a cemetery was located, containing many burial *loculi* that had been plundered.

(3) **The water system:** This was found in the central part of the northern



183. Bird's-eye view of Khirbet el-Ḥamam, looking north, 1984. Note the ramp, Roman road and dyke. Photo: M. Weinberg.

slope of Ḥamam A, overlooking Wadi Jiz, and located under the Iron Age city wall line. Three large plastered cisterns were detected, each capable of holding 300-1000 cu. m of water. Supply of water to the cisterns was via a channel that collected the water from the city's roofs and streets and from the plastered slope above the city.

(4) **The approach road:** The city was approached from the west via a built road. It started at the Roman road from Caesarea to Ginae (see Zertal 1986), branching off southward at Khirbet Samarraḥ. From there the approach road passes over the broad ridge descending south-west to the hilltop of el-Kuleileh, and turns east at the saddle on which there is a siege camp (D). The road descends to Wadi Jiz, and then ascends eastward to the site to the southern slope of Ḥamam A. Part of the approach way, including the support walls, was uncovered in 1981 in the excavation of the central section of the site.

(5) **The siege works:** Khirbet el-Ḥamam was surrounded by a Roman siege system, including a circumvallation, a siege ramp, and siege camps. This is the only Roman siege system north of Jerusalem, and is associated with the Great Revolt of the Jews against the Romans in 66-73 CE.

The circumvallation is a stone wall 2.2 m thick (7 Roman feet), 1516 m long, surrounding about 75% of the site's circumference at a distance of 400-500 m from it. It begins in the west, from where it crosses the wadi



184. View of the tell to the north. The Roman ramp is visible in the centre of the saddle.

and runs along the northern low slope of Wadi Jiz. Here it crosses Wadi Jiz again and ascends to the hill of el-Birkeh, to siege Camp B. From Camp B the circumvallation descends slightly southward and vanishes. Apparently its incompleteness stems from the quick surrender of the city of Nabatah, rendering the siege system superfluous.

The ramp is in the middle of the saddle that connects Ḥamam A to Ḥamam B, and is 130 m long and about 4.5 m wide. In its southern part it spreads out to become a wide triangle, probably a construction used to assemble the siege machinery. The ramp is built of two parallel walls with filling between them, and rises about 1 m above the surface of the saddle. Its functioning as a siege ramp is not entirely clear. It does not reach the city walls, and relates to structures which are in front of the approach way. With regard to the dating it fits the siege, but its construction has not been completed.

(6) **Camps:** Three fortified camps were found surrounding the tell: two were adjacent to the circumvallation, while the third (Camp B) formed part of it. The former two were found in the centre (Camp C) and on the saddle near Khirbet el-Kuleileh (Camp D). Camp C, which was not excavated, is a structure, 13×15 m, containing rooms. Camp D is larger (25×30 m), and is some kind of built enclosure, similar to known Roman camps. Camp B, on the hill of el-Birkeh, was excavated in 1980 (Site 147).

Pottery: Ḥamam A: Iron Ib (11th–10th centuries BCE) – 10%; Iron II – 20%; Persian – 30%; Hellenistic – 10%; Early Roman – 30%. Ḥamam B: Iron II – 5%; Persian – 5%; Late Hellenistic and Early Roman – 90%. Siege system: Roman (1st century CE) – 100%.

Identification and historical summary: The site has been identified as Arubboth, the capital of the Third District of Solomon (I Kgs 4:10), Arbatha of the Book of Hasmoneans, (I Macc 5: 21-23), and Nabatah of the Great Revolt (War II xiv, 5; xviii, 10). Accordingly, the site was of importance from the days of the United Monarchy (10th century BCE) as the administrative capital of the region. Apparently this function continued in the Hellenistic period, and especially in the Roman one, when the city served as the capital of the toparchy of Nabatah. During the Great Revolt, zealots from Caesarea used the place as a stronghold after the uprisings in the city during Passover of the year 66 CE. In the campaign of Cestius Gallus in Judea, apparently at the end of the year 66, a Roman siege system was erected around the site. The archaeological evidence show that this brought about the fall of the city. The siege system has been dated to the 1st century CE.

The identification of the site as Arubboth may solve the question regarding the extent of Solomon's districts and the principles of their division; see additional discussion in Chapter 2.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 41.

Additional Bibliography: Alt 1926: 5 ff; Klein 1930; 1939: 110; Grintz 1957: 12 ff; Avi-Yonah 1963: 126-127; Zertal 1993a; 1995; 2002b.



Site 147: 16-20/31/1

El-Birkeh

Israel grid: 1630 2019

UTM grid: 7008 5882

Elevation: 216 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: siege camp

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: edge of ridge

Rock type: Judah group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
3 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 400 m
distant

Visibility: 3

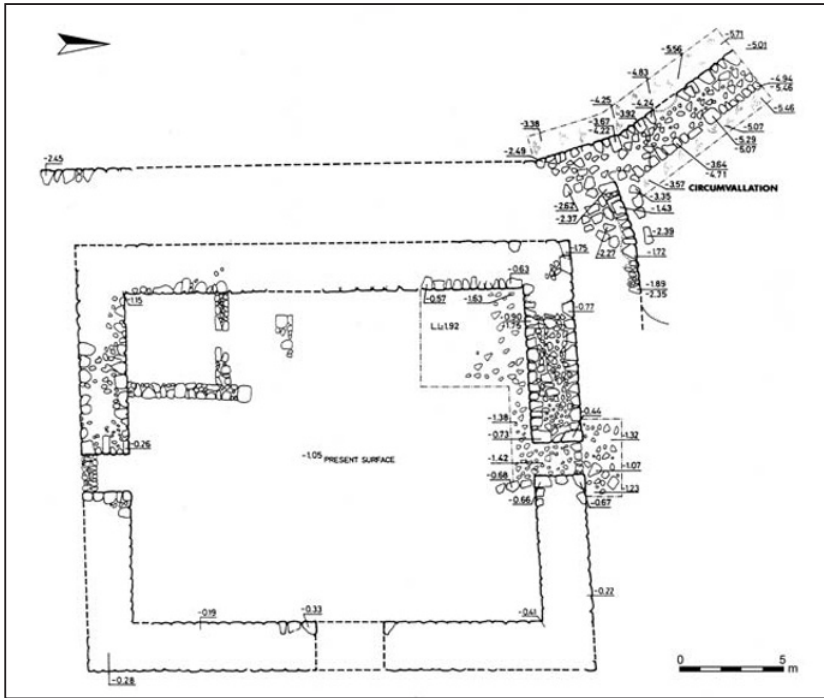
Date of visit: 1978, 1980-1990;

Excavation 1980

A site on a rocky ridge east of Khirbet el-Ḥamam (Arubboth/Narbatah), in the hilly area south of Wadi Jiz.

The site was excavated in 1980, part of the project on the Roman siege of Narbatah in the 1st century CE. A square camp (Camp B) was uncovered, surrounded by a 2.2 m-thick wall whose outer sides were each 23 m long. It has two entrances, on the north and south, opposite each other. The entrances are paved in stone, and are 1.7 m wide. The camp was connected to the circumvallation that surrounded Khirbet el-Ḥamam: it came from the north, turned into part of the western wall of the camp, and continued southward from the south-west corner.

Only the western half of the camp was excavated. At a depth of about 1 m from the surface, a beaten earth floor was exposed, upon which were many sherds and built stoves with cooking pots. At the south-west corner a square room, 4×4 m, was found. According to the coinage and ceramic evi-



dence, the camp was built in the 1st century CE. Stratigraphically it belongs to the siege, which is dated by conjecture to 66 CE, the beginning of the Great Revolt.

Pottery: Iron Ib – 5%; Persian – 5%; Hellenistic – 10%; Early Roman – 80%.

Coins: Herod Archelais and Antonius Felix.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 148: 16-20/31/1

Khirbet Baṭnet el-Khenazir

Israel grid: 1623 2009

UTM grid: 7002 5872

Elevation: 233 m a.s.l., 35 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: small ruin

Area: 3.5 dunams (3500 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop and ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat group

Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 11

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
1.8 km distant

Road: 'Illar-Ra'y (A3), 1 km distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Nov. 1978, Jan. 1979;

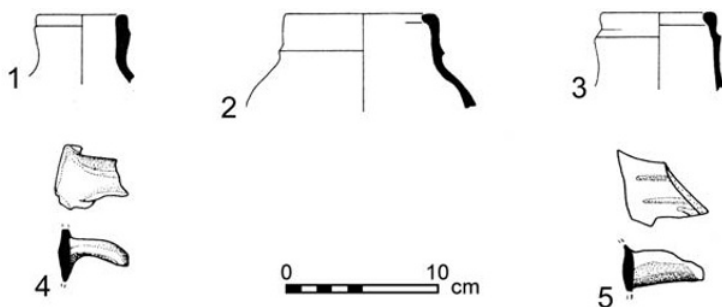
40 sherds

A site on a flat, chalky ridge in the hilly area between Wadi Jiz and the Şeida range. North of the site, the area descends toward Wadi Jiz, and south of it descends to Wadi Mughraqah. About 700 m to the north-east is Khirbet el-Ḥamam (Site 146).

The settlement is situated on a platform that was levelled by terraces, and whose dimensions are about 50×70 m. On the surface at least five structures with adjacent courtyards were found. All the masonry was of large field stones (150×40×40 cm on the average). Judging by the wall thickness and quality of construction, most of the buildings may have had a second story.

On the south-western part of the platform, near the buildings, an 'industrial area' was found, containing an olive press *in situ*, a rock-cut cistern, various agricultural installations, and many quarried places.

The slopes below the site, both to the south and north, are terraced and



186. Pottery from Khirbet Baṭnet el-Khenazir: 1.Jug, lt, Hel-ER; 2.Jar, lt, Hel-ER; 3.Jug, lt, Hel-ER; 4-5.Jug handles, lt, ER.

contain sherd scatters. Various buildings may once have stood there.

This settlement seems to be a subsidiary village of nearby Narbatah, and was abandoned or destroyed at the same time. The masonry, ceramics, and installation details are identical to those of Roman Narbatah.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 30%; Early Roman – 70%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 50.



Site 149: 16-20/41/1

Khirbet Umm-Kaḥal

Israel grid: 1644 2015

UTM grid: 7022 5877

Elevation: 316 m a.s.l., 48 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: medium-sized

Area: 6 dunams (6000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop on
mountainous height

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: groves

Cisterns: 6

Water source: Bir Shafur [‘Einot
Faḥmeh] (no. 45), 3.2 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 1 km
distant

Visibility: 5

Date of visit: 1978–1979, several
visits, plan: Oct. 1997; 50 sherds

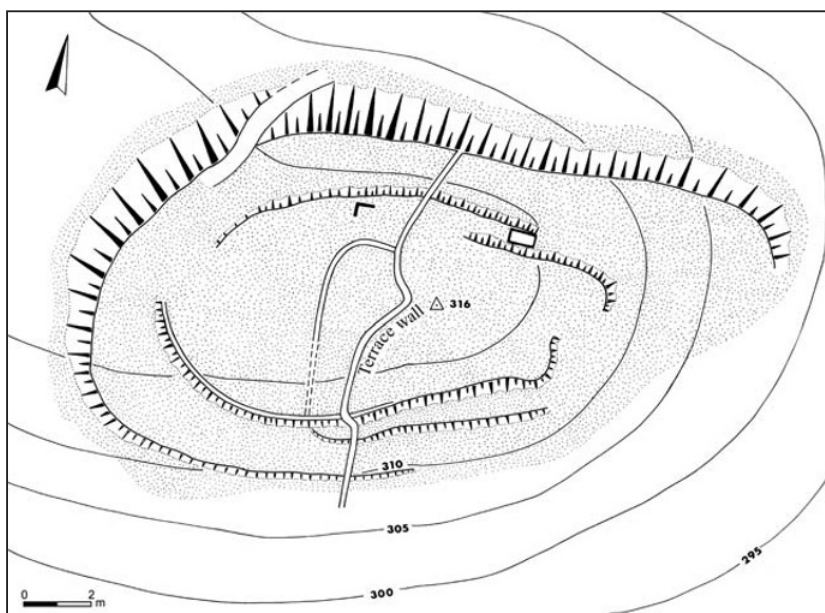
A site on a dominant hilltop at the edge of a long ridge that descends northwards from the Dhahret Khais Range toward Wadi Jiz. It is located in the hilly area south of the Dothan Valley, about 2.5 km south-west of Mevo Dothan.

Next to the site, to the east, runs a built path from Jami’ Ṭubrus to Ya’bad. From the summit, steep slopes descend to the north and west. In the centre is a newly-built terrace wall, dividing the place north-south. The whole eastern part of the ruin has been destroyed and converted into an olive grove. The western part is untouched (1997). The western part is surrounded by a stone wall 1–2 m thick, which was possibly a fortification wall. Within this part were several buildings, some of them apparently four-roomed houses. All the structures are built of large field stones, with four monoliths found *in situ* in one of them.

On the hilltop itself, and on the slopes to the north and west, is a considerable sherd scatter. East of the olive grove is a sherd scatter from the Roman period.



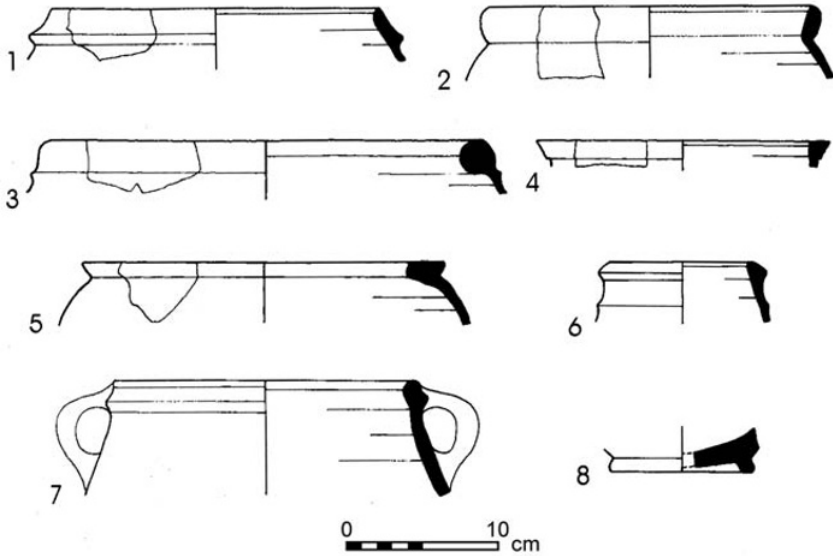
187. Bird's-eye view of Khirbet Umm Kaḥal, looking south-west. 1998.
(Photo – M. Weinberg).



188. Plan of Khirbet Umm Kaḥal, 1998.

Pottery: Iron II – 90%; Late Roman – 5%; Byzantine – 5%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no 43.



189. Pottery from Khirbet Umm Kaḥal: 1.CP, dk, IA I; 2.Krater, brn, IA I; 3.CP, brn, IA II; 4.Bowl, lt, IA II; 5.HM, gr, IA II; 6.Jar, gr, IA II; 7.CP, dk, IA II; 8.Bowl base, lt, IA II.



Site 150: 16-20/41/2

Khirbet Ṭubrus et-Taḥta

Israel grid: 1646 2011

UTM grid: 7025 5873

Elevation: 310 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: medium-sized ruin

Area: about 10 dunams (1 ha)

Topography: broad ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: olive groves

Cisterns: 8

Water source: Bir Shafur [‘Einot Faḥmeh] (no. 45), 2.7 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 1.3 km distant

Visibility: 6

Date of visit: Oct. 1997; 49 sherds

A ruin on a broad ridge that descends from Dhahret Khais Range to the north-west, through Jami' Ṭubrus, and in the direction of Wadi Jiz. The place is completely cultivated with olive trees. An unpaved road from Faḥmeh to Wadi Jiz passes east of it.

The site spreads over a saddle and a hilltop, with the majority of the building traces being on the northern hilltop. It contains walls of large monoliths, which might have served as terrace walls. All over the hilltop are many quarried places and caves, some of them possibly burial caves. The walls of the structures have been completely dismantled, but it appears that a village or small settlement was once situated here.

Pottery: Persian – 10%; Hellenistic – 15%; Early Roman – 20%; Late Roman – 30%; Byzantine – 25%.

Previous surveys: None.



Site 151: 16-20/71/1

El-Khirbeh ('Arrabeh)

Israel grid: 1676 2017

UTM grid: 7055 5880

Elevation: 336 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: tell

Area: about 9 dunams (9000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop on

mountainous height

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: olive groves

Cisterns: 4

Water source: Bir Shafur ['Einot

Faḥmeh] (no. 45), 2.5 km distant

Road: Jatt-Ta'anach (A3), 3 km

distant

Visibility: 5

Date of visit: May, Sept. 1978;

46 sherds

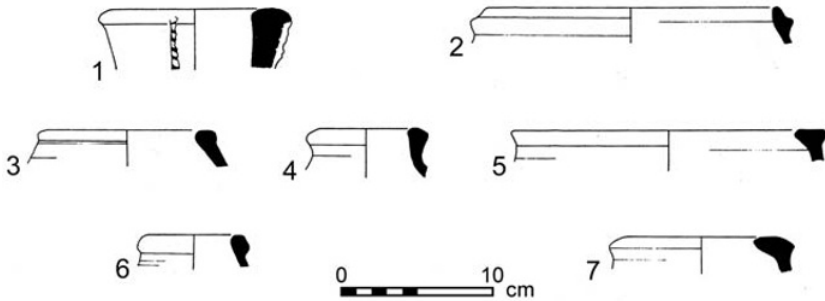
A medium-sized tell on a round hilltop, covered with olive trees. It is located 1.2 km west of the village of 'Arrabeh, and south of the Dothan Valley. There is a good view from it to the Faḥmeh range (south).

The site is best approached from the north and east, with a convenient built path that leads from 'Arrabeh to Khirbet el-Qureinat. Steep slopes descend southward to deep Wadi Ghurab, a tributary of Wadi Jiz. In the eastern part of the hilltop are stone mounds and walls in which building stones are combined. In the western part a few remnants of walls have

been preserved, as well as many quarried places, caves, and agricultural installations. At the top of the southern slope is a high terrace wall that may have served as fortification. In the eastern part, near the path to 'Arrabeh, many well-cut openings of burial caves were found plundered.

Pottery: Iron II – 20%; Persian – 25%; Hellenistic – 15%; Early Roman – 10%; Late Roman – 10%; Byzantine – 5%; Early Moslem – 5%; Middle Ages – 10%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no 44.



190. Pottery from el-Khirbeh ('Arrabeh): 1. Jar, lt, Pers; 2. CP, dk, IA II; 3-4. Jars, brn, IA II; 5. Krater, brn, IA II; 6. Jar, yel, Pers; 7. HM, gr, IA II.



Site 152: 16-20/91/1

'Arrabeh

Israel grid: 1695 2011

UTM grid: 7074 5875

Elevation: 380 m a.s.l., 25 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map, but not as ancient site

Site type: town on ruin

Area: 25 dunams (2.5 ha)
(ancient core)

Topography: mountainous height

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 60

Water source: Bir Shafur ['Einot Fahmeh] (no. 45), 3 km distant

Road: Fahmeh-Kabatiyeh (C4),
400 m distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Feb. 1979, 40 sherds

A large Arab town in the hilly area south of the Dothan Valley, just west of the ancient and modern roads from the Dothan Valley to Sebastiyeh. 'Arrabeh, a town of 10,000 inhabitants, is situated on an ancient site which is located in the south-eastern part of the town.

The pottery of the ancient core was examined. This core (dated to the Ottoman period and situated next to the central mosque) has been obliterated by modern construction. Some traces of walls are still visible, as well as burial caves in secondary use, quarried places and installations. A great many of the ancient houses have been destroyed.

In 1105 the village of 'Arrabeh was mentioned by the traveller 'Abd el-Ghani, and in 1229 Yaqut wrote that the village has a holy place named after the Prophet Arabil. During the Crusader period, 'Arrabeh appears as part of a chain of settlements that marked the eastern boundary of Caesarea (Beyer 1940: 183, 192). In the Ottoman census of 1596 the village was in the Jebel Shami province, and included 112 taxpayers; 81 married, and 31 bachelors, all Moslems. The village paid 29275 *aqia* in tax, of which 17040 were for wheat, 1500 for barley, 2683 for summer crops, 2500 for olives and 300 for *jizia* (Hütteroth and 'Abdulfattah 1977: 128). The Turkish traveller Evliya Tshalebi, who visited the site in 1648-50, describes the village as follows: "Accompanied by fifty armed mounted beduins we went for five hours in a southerly direction, then for another hour through the valley of Jinin [the Dothan Valley, A.Z.], passed the village of Qabatye and arrived at 'Arrabe. It consists of a hundred Moslem houses and [its revenue] is set aside for the pasha, who is governor of Nablus." (Stephan 1938: 88).

The British Survey describes it as: "'Arrabeh – A very large village on the south slope of a ridge, the northern houses on high ground. There is a small mosque in the centre, and one or two large buildings, including the Sheikh's house. The water supply is entirely from wells within the village, and on the road-side towards the north. There is a ridge of very barren rock between the village on the south and the plain (Merj 'Arrabeh) on the north. Scattered olives grow round the village, but the immediate neighbourhood is very bare. The villagers are turbulent and rich, owning very fine lands in the northern plain." (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 154).

Guérin (1969b: 218-219) wrote "At one o'clock we reached 'Arrabeh. This town is situated on a height, below which extends a very well cultivated valley. It has 3000 residents or more, and is divided into three quarters, one of which is surrounded by a fence wall reinforced by small towers. This wall was destroyed due to a siege that was placed on the town about a dozen years ago (1858) by the *Qaimaqam* (governor) of Nablus since the residents rose

up against him. Many homes were also destroyed then, and most of them have been rebuilt since then. The town of 'Arrabeh is certainly located on the site of an ancient city of which there is no trace in the literature but which seems to have borne the same name. Many hewn cisterns cut into rock have survived since then, and many ashlar are integrated in new dwelling places. During the Christian period, before the Moslem conquest, a church stood here. Its place was taken by a mosque that was built on its ruins, which is now about to fall apart. Above the entrance is a handsome monolithic lintel of white marble, in the centre of which is a carved cross with arms of equal length which the Moslems ruined. It was inside a rectangle next to two triangles on its two ends, right and left; all this was in a kind of rectangular frame. The lintel itself was sufficient to attribute this church to the period I have mentioned. The interior of the church was decorated with columns bearing Corinthian capitals and grooves, half of them coiled and half straight and upright. A few of them have survived, damaged, and remain in the mosque, as well as a fine section of a frieze on which intertwined chain links were carved" [translated from French, A.Z.].

In the 1931 census the village had 2500 residents and 554 inhabited houses (Vilnay 1968: 327). The village was the centre for the well-known 'Abd el-Hadi family.

Pottery (in ancient core): Late Roman – 15%; Byzantine – 30%; Early Moslem – 15%; Middle Ages – 15%; Ottoman – 20%; Modern – 5%.

Previous surveys: None.

Additional Bibliography: Salem 2006: site 29; 2008: 218-219.

Site 153: 17-20/01/2

Esh-Shuneh

Israel grid: 1702 2012

UTM grid: 7080 5876

Elevation: 385 m a.s.l., 35 m a.s.a.

Name type: known as ancient, but not on map

Site type: medium-sized site and cemetery

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: steep hilltop at edge of ridge

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: olive grove

Cisterns: 4

Water source: Bir Haffireh (no. 40), 2.5 km distant

Road: Deir Sharaf-Jenin (B4), 1 km distant

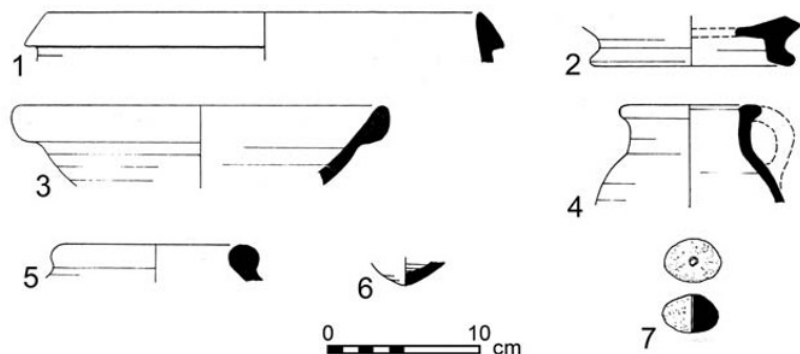
Visibility: 3

Date of visit: Mar. 1979; 51 sherds

A medium-sized site on a high flat hilltop, connected by a ridge only to the west. It is situated on a range that borders the Dothan Valley to the south, and comprises part of the village of 'Arrabeh, the centre of which is 500 m west of it.

To the north, east, and west the site is surrounded by deep wadis, and on the northern and western parts new houses have been built. Along the edge of the slope to the north and east, a stone wall was found standing to a height of about 3 m. This may have served as a boundary wall or a fortification. It did not extend south or west, and thus it may also have been merely a cultivation terrace.

On the eastern part of the hilltop, two sherd scatters were found. There



191. Pottery from esh-Shuneh: 1.CP, dk, IA I-II; 2.Mortaria base, yel, Pers; 3.Bowl, yel, Pers; 4.Jug, gr, Pers; 5.Jar, brn, IA I-II; 6.Juglet base, lt, Pers; 7.Clay weight.

are also concentrations of drafted building stones that were recently extracted from walls. Around the stones are large fragments of jars from the Persian period. All of these indicate several houses that stood here during that period and were destroyed and plundered, either for their antiquities, or in preparation of the land for cultivation and construction.

The southern part of the hilltop has many quarried places, agricultural installations, and cisterns. On the eastern slope there are openings of burial caves that have been plundered.

Pottery: Iron I-II – 5%; Iron III – 5%; Persian – 85%; Middle Ages – 5%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 47.



Site 154: 16-20/10/2

Wadi Shiḥan

Israel grid: 1612 2004

UTM grid: 6991 5866

Elevation: 235 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat group

Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: groves

Cisterns: 4

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
1 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 1.8 km
distant

Visibility: 2

Date of visit: Jan. 1979; 18 sherds

A small site on a ridge descending into Wadi Shiḥan, in the hilly area north of Şeida.

At the site is a central structure built of large uncut stones, with sides 7 m long and about 1 m high. The structure is now covered with cleared stones, and it was hard to make out its internal plan. In the centre of the structure a large lime pit was dug, which destroyed parts of it.

South of the central structure is another, smaller one, also covered with cleared stones. Next to the two structures are a winepress, quarried places, cupmarks, and other installations. On the western slope the entrance to a cave was found. There was little pottery.

Pottery: Persian – 50%; Byzantine – 50%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 155: 16-20/30/2

Khirbet 'Arrar

Israel grid: 1631 2003

UTM grid: 7009 5866

Elevation: 270 m a.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: village

Area: 6.4 dunams (6400 sq. m)

Topography: slope

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: at least 7

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
2.3 km distant

Road: Narbatah Road (C1), 1.3 km
distant

Visibility: 2

Date of visit: Nov. 1978, Feb. 1980;
44 sherds

A well-preserved village on a long slope descending from the range of Khirbet Barquneh westward to Wadi Jiz. It is about 2 km north-east of Şeida and in the hilly area between Şeida, Kafr Ra'y, and Khirbet el-Ḥamam.

The village is built upon a set of very wide man-made terraces on the slope. On the surfaces that were created by the terraces, at least 15 units of



192. View of Khirbet 'Arrar, looking south-east. In the distance is Barquneh Range, 1978. Photo: A. Zertal. Due to preparation of the land for cultivation, the site no longer exists.

houses and courtyards were found. Their plans have been rendered indistinct by the piles of field stones, but it is possible to distinguish structures containing several rooms, and next to them rectangular or irregular-shaped courtyards. Most of the structures' walls stand to a height of at least two courses. The masonry is of large, well-drafted stones. Among the ruins are many architectural elements: threshold stones, lintels, doorposts, etc. Among the structures, which are not especially close together, are quarried places: a winepress, quarries, cupmarks, and various other installations. On the southern slope are four openings of plundered burial caves.

The village of Khirbet 'Arrar was apparently one of the subsidiary villages of Nabatah. Judging by the pottery, the place was abandoned at the end of the 1st century CE. According to the field workers of the area, residents of Kafr Ra'y, the name is ancient, but its origin is unknown.

During a return visit in 1997 it was found that the site had been completely destroyed and had been turned into an olive grove.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 10%; Early Roman – 90%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 51.



Site 156: 16-20/30/1

Khirbet Barquneh

Israel grid: 1636 2000

UTM grid: 7015 5863

Elevation: 310 m a.s.l., 35 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: large ruin

Area: 12 dunams (1.2 ha)

Topography: hilltop and ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat group

Soil type: rendzina and brown forest

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 17

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
2.5 km distant

Road: 'Illar–Ra'y (C3), at site

Visibility: 7

Date of visit: Mar. 1978, Jan. 1980,
Sept. 1997; 82 sherds

A large site on a flat hilltop at the watershed between Şeida and Faḥmeh. This watershed drains its water southward to Wadi Massin and northward to Wadi Jiz. Today an unpaved road from Şeida to the village of Ra'y passes through the site. There is a good view from the site to Kafr Ra'y and the Dothan Valley.

The site extends over a very large area. It is spread out, with structural remains and building complexes at a distance from each other. Most of the structures consist of a courtyard-house with rooms built of cut stones made of local chalk and limestone. Most of the walls stand up to 1 m high (two courses). In many places, sections of columns were found, as well as some threshold stones, and doorposts *in situ*. About 20 such courtyard-house complexes were counted.

On the northern part of the site, an olive press was found with almost all its parts intact. It includes a crushing surface for olives and two upright stones with a hole, as well as three pillar sections.

All over the site's surface are many quarried places, cisterns, and caves. A considerable sherd scatter was found on and around the site.

This is a typical Roman-Byzantine village that has been well preserved with its houses and characteristics. The oil press was especially impressive.

During a return visit in Sept. 1997 it became apparent that most of the site had been destroyed for cultivation.

Pottery: Early Roman – 5%; Late Roman – 10%; Byzantine – 85%.

Identification: It has been proposed to identify this site as Barkatah, which is associated with Ferasin in the *halachot* and discussions on relations between Jews and Samaritans: see Chapter 2.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 52.



Site 157: 16-20/30/3

Khirbet Umm-Kashaf

Israel grid: 1639 2003

UTM grid: 7018 5865

Elevation: 330 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: farm

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop and slope

Rock type: 'Avdat group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 3

Water source: Bir es-Siflani (no. 43),
3 km distant

Road: 'Illar-Ra'y (C3), 400 m distant

Visibility: 6

Date of visit: Aug. 1979; 39 sherds

A small site on a ridge in the hilly area, about 2.5 km north of Kafr Ra'y. The ridge is part of the watershed between Wadi Jiz in the north and Wadi Sultan in the south. An unpaved road from Kafr Ra'y to Khirbet el-Ḥamam passes next to the village.

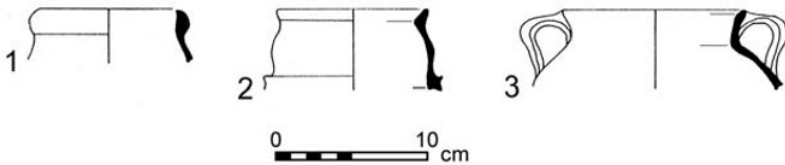
Traces of three small structures were detected. The middle one is 5×10 m: its plan has been made indistinct by piles of stones. Next to it are openings of several cisterns, rock-cut installations, and an oil press *in situ*.

A few dozen metres to the east is another, smaller structure. On the ridge, north of the former, is a concentration of rock-cut agricultural installations.

The whole complex apparently belonged to a farm from the Roman period. It is very reasonable to assume that the site belonged to the Nabatah region.

Pottery: Roman – 100%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 53.



193. Pottery from Khirbet Umm-Kashaf: 1-2. Jars, brn, Rom; 3. CP, brn, LR.



Site 158: 16-20/50/1

Jami' Ṭubrus

Israel grid: 1651 2006

UTM grid: 7030 5869

Elevation: 375 m a.s.l., 80 m a.s.a.

Name type: appears on map as
ancient

Site type: medium-sized

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop on slope

Rock type: 'Avdat group

Soil type: rendzina and terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: olive groves

Cisterns: 7

Water source: Bir Shafur ['Einot

Faḥmeh] (no. 45), 2.2 km distant

Road: 'Illar-Ra'y (C3), 700 m distant

Visibility: 7

Date of visit: Mar. 1978; 51 sherds

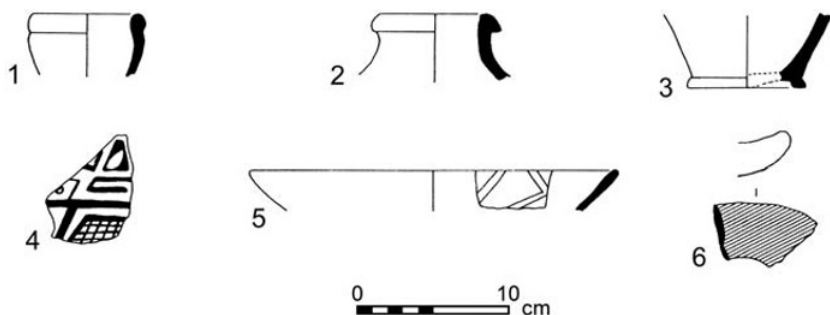
A ruin on a high hilltop on a slope in the hilly area descending into Wadi Jiz, north of Dhahret Khais Range and 2.7 km north of Kafr Ra'y. A good path from Faḥmeh passes through the site, with an unpaved road to Umm-Kaḥal. There is a fine view of Umm-Kaḥal and Khirbet el-Ḥamam.

At the site are remains of three large, semi-ruined structures, made of field stones reinforced with chalky mortar and plastered. The masonry is good. The roofs rest on interior stone arches, some of them still *in situ*. In addition to these central structures, there are remains of many more ruined buildings, whose plans are hard to discern. Many field stone walls of these buildings have survived.

On the surface of the site there are also five rock-cut oil and winepresses with other installations, caves, and cisterns. On the western slope is a large cemetery containing dozens of rock-cut tombs. On the southern part of the site is a large pile of earth containing sherds, apparently from clearing the ancient structures.

The village appears on the list of estates awarded by the Mamluk Sultan Baibars in 1265 after the victory over the Crusaders (Abel 1939: 41). In the Ottoman census of 1596 the village had 57 Moslem taxpayers who paid: wheat – 710 *aqia*; barley 250 *aqia*; summer crops – 250 *aqia*; olives – 500 *aqia* (equal to 1000 trees), goats and honeybees – 270 *aqia*, olive presses – 12 *aqia*; jizia – 2280 *aqia*. The total annual tax was 4522 *aqia* (Hütteroth and 'Abdulfattah 1977: 125). In the British Survey this site was described as: "heaps of stones, a well, and two sacred places" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 216) but no village is mentioned. In Grossman's view (1986: 351) it was destroyed in the 16th century, apparently due to local wars. It is not mentioned by Guérin.

The origin of the name comes from the sacred structures for which the



194. Pottery from Jami' Ṭubrus: 1.Jug, dk, Byz; 2.Jar, gr, Pers; 3.Jug base, lt, MA; 4.Dec, brn on wh, Mam (MA); 5.Bowl, green-yel glaze, MA; 6.Ledge handle, lt, MA.

site was famous (*jama/Jami'* = mosque). The name *Tubrus* is interesting; it may be a corruption of the name Tiberius.

Pottery: Persian – 2%; Early Roman – 10%; Late Roman – 10%; Byzantine – 18%; Early Moslem – 10%; Middle Ages (mostly Mamluk) – 30%; Ottoman – 10%; Modern – 10%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 54.



Site 159: 16-20/60/1

Es-Sbeihah

Israel grid: 1662 2008

UTM grid: 7041 5871

Elevation: 325 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: structure

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop and slope

Rock type: Mount Scopus group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 2

Water source: Bir Shafur ['Einot Fahmeh] (no. 45), 1.5 km distant

Road: Yemmeh-Zawiyeh (C2), 3 km distant

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Feb. 1979; 19 sherds

A small site on a hilltop in the centre of a long moderate slope that descends from the high range near Baṭn Umm-Nari northward to Wadi Jiz.

On the hilltop is a small ruined three-roomed Arab house with a courtyard. The house is made of field stones and mortar; and the roof has collapsed into the rooms. Apparently it was built at the end of the 19th century or the beginning of the 20th. Around the house are walls *in situ*, made of cut field stones, quarried places, and agricultural installations. A rock-cut cistern was also found, but its dating and use are unclear. There was a light sherd scatter, and it seems that one or two houses stood here during the Byzantine period.

Pottery: Byzantine – 100%.

Previous surveys: Zertal 1984: no. 55.

Site 160: 15-19/39/1

Zeita (West)

Israel grid: 1542 1993

UTM grid: 6921 5854

Elevation: 80 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: very large

Area: about 300 dunams (30 ha)

Topography: ravine at edge of valley

Rock type: alluvium covering

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Water source: Bir Zeita (no. 150),
800 m distant

Road: Jatt–Megiddo (A1), at site

Visibility: 4

Date of visit: Dec. 1987; 223 sherds

A very large site, spread out over the north-western fringes of the 'Ibthan Valley, about 100 m north-west of Kibbutz Magal, and west of the village of Zeita.

In the centre of the site is the modern road from the junction of 'Iron to Tulkarm: this is the historical route that appears in many ancient Egyptian sources. On the surface, over a large area between Magal and Zeita and southward to Jatt, on the plain and on low hills, an exceptionally large amount of sherds and building stones was found. Apparently, buildings were scattered over most of this area, but their walls were pulled out of the ground over time in order to cultivate the land.

In the western part is the Chalcolithic material (pottery, flint, and basalt finds). In the east, at the edges of a grove on the west side of the village of Zeita, were found some sherds from the Middle and Late Bronze Age.

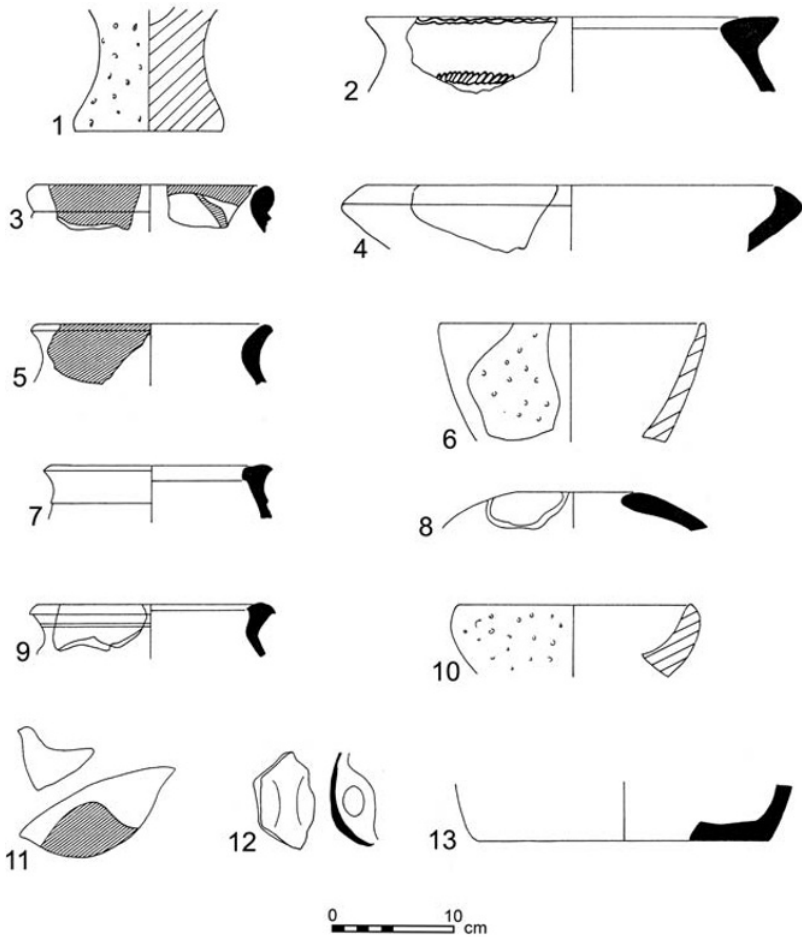
This unfortified site is the largest in the region, and extended southward to the fortified tell of Jatt (Gath Padallah?), and perhaps was also part of it.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 20%; Early Bronze I – 40%; Early Bronze II – 20%; Middle Bronze II – 18%; Late Bronze – 2%.

Identification: This is one of the candidates to be identified as *h-b-d-n*, from the Egyptian sources; see Chapter 2.

Previous surveys: None.

Bibliography: Goren et al. 2004: 346.



195. Pottery and other finds from Zeita (West): 1. Pedestal base, Chal, basalt; 2. Pithos, rd-gr; Chal; 3. Jar, rd slip, coarse, EB I; 4. Platter, yel, EB I; 5. Jar, rd slip, EB I; 6, 10. Bowls, basalt, Chal; 7. Jar, yel, MB II; 8. HM, dk, EB I; 9. Jar, yel, EB I; 11. Ledge handle, EB; 12. Perforated handle, yel, Chal; 13. Jar base, yel, EB I.